INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA AN OPEN READER

Edited and with an introduction by
David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

a mediastudies.press
open reader

Independent, Alternative, and Community Media: An Open Reader

Edited by David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

© 2026 David W. Park & Meghan Grosse

Works not in the public domain are licensed under a Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial 4.0 International *(CC BY-NC 4.0)*. This license allows you to share, copy, distribute and transmit the text; to adapt the text for non-commercial purposes of the text providing attribution is made to the authors *(but not in any way that suggests that they endorse you or your use of the work)*.



Published by:
mediastudies.press
414 W. Broad St.
Bethlehem, PA 18018, USA

Copy-editing: Emily Alexander

Cover design: Natascha Chtena

Landing page: mediastudies.press/iacmedia

Open Reader series - issn *(online)* 2770-940X | issn *(print)* 3143-4509

isbn 978-1-951399-33-7 *(print)* | isbn 978-1-951399-30-6 *(pdf)*

isbn 978-1-951399-32-0 *(epub)* | isbn 978-1-951399-31-3 *(html)*

doi 10.64629/3f8575cb.638fbdwo | lccn 2025938544

Edition 1 published in August 2026

Contents

Introduction: The Promise and Vulnerability of Independent, Alternative, and Community Media
David W. Park and Meghan Grosse xvii

PART 1: CONCEPTUALIZING INDEPENDENT, ALTERNATIVE, AND COMMUNITY MEDIA

There is No Alternative: The Critical Potential of Alternative Media in the Face of Neoliberalism
Linus Andersson 1

Uncommunicative Partners: Social Movement Media Analysis and Radcial Educators
John D. H. Downing 20

Communication and Struggles for Alternatives
Christian Fuchs 29

What We Talk About When We Talk About "Media Independence"
Karl Karpinnen and Hallvard Moe 43

The Unbearable Lightness of Being Alternative: Idealism-Realism and Purism-Pragmatism in Greek Alternative Media
Dimitra L. Milioni and Pantelis Vatikiotis. 59

PART 2: HISTORY, MEMORY, AND ARCHIVES

Hand-Made Memories: Remediating Cultural Memory in DIY Feminist Networks
Red Chidgey 83

Being a Child of the Mines: Youth Magazines and Comics in the Copperbelt
Enid Guene 93

Social Participation in Indonesian Media and Art: Echoes from the Past, Visions for the Future
Edwin Jurriëns 112

Learning from the History of Alternative Communciation Networks
Félix Tréguer, Dominique Trudel, and Mélanie Dulong de Rosnay 134

A Brief History of CCLM/CLMP
Pauline Uchmanowicz 152

Promising Prospects, and the Hurdles Along the Way: Sharing and Archiving Community Media Content Online
Joost van Beek 163

PART 3: POLICY, REGULATIONS, AND GOVERNMENT INTERVENTION

Media at the Margins: Policy and Practice in American, Canadian, and British Community Television
Christopher Ali 173

News by Any Other Name: Community Radio Journalism in India
Bridget Backhaus 192

'In the Waiting Room': Digitsation and Post-Neoliberalism in Buenos Aires
Geoff Baker 208

From Revolution to Reform: Recommendations for Spectrum Policy in Transitional Tunisia
Moez Chakchouk, Danielle Kehl, Jochai Ben-Avie, and Kate Coyer 244

From Media Niche to Policy Spotlight: Mapping Community-Media Policy Change in Latin America
Arne Hintz 269

Community Radio Contradictions in Canada: Learning from Volunteers Impacted by Commercialising Policies and Practices
Gretchen King and Omme-Salma Rahemtullah 282

PART 4: PRODUCTION AND DISTRIBUTION

Podcasting About Yourself and Challenging Norms: An Investigation of Independent Women Podcasters in Denmark
Freja Sørine Adler Berg 305

The Business of DIY: Characteristics, Motives and Ideologies of Microindependent Record Labels
Robin den Drijver and Erik Hitters 323

Intervention for Inclusivity: Gender Politics and Indie Game Development
Stephanie Fisher and Alison Harvey 342

From Art House to Your House: The Distribution of Quality Cinema on Home Video
Daniel Herbert 358

SoundCloud and Bandcamp as Alternative Music Platforms
David Hesmondhalgh, Ellis Jones, and Andreas Rauh 373

Indie or Mainstream? Tensions and Nuances between the Alternative and the Mainstrean in Indie Games
Ólivier Pérez-Latorre 393

Making Media Together: Experiences of Aboriginal Participation within Co-Creative Remote Media Production Teams
Laura McDowell. 408

Participatory Film Production as Media Practice
Antoni Roig Telo 427

PART 5: LABOR, FUNDING, AND PROMOTION

Indie Cinema and Short Film Assemblage
Thomas Barker 449

Independent Canadian Music in the Streaming Age
Andrew deWaard, Brian Fauteux, and Brianne Selman 459

Crowdfunding for Independent Print Media: E-Commerce, Marketing, and Business Development
Peter Konhäusner, Marius Thielmann, Veronica Thielmann, Veronica Câmpian, and Dan-Cristian Dabija 489

'Let's Keep Music Special. F—Spotify': On-Demand Streaming and the Controversy over Artist Royalties
Lee Marshall 513

DIY or Die? A Typology of DIY Careers in the Portuguese Independent Music Scenes
Ana Oliveira 528

The Political Economy of Financially Successful Independent Hip-Hop Artists
Geoff Ostrove. 544

Autonomy, Integration, and the Work of Cultural Intermediation in Indie Games
Matthew E. Perks, Felan Parker, Jennifer R. Whitson, Gabrielle Lavenir, Ceyda Yolgörmez, Pierson Browne, and Brian Schram 564

Seeking Deep Relations in a Precarious Industry: Addressing Mental Health through Independent Videogame Development
Paulo Ruffino 584

PART 6: MESSAGES, NARRATIVES, AND REPRESENTATIONS

What I Know Now: Radio as a Means of Empowerment for Women of Lived Prison Experience
Heather Anderson and Charlotte Bedford. 603

Are You Okay? Mental Health Narratives in Art Zines from the Zineopolis Collection
Jackie Batey 619

"I Want to Tell You about My Life Now": The Voice of Palestinian Refugees in Frontiers of Dreams and Fears
Catherine Burwell 633

American Realities on Public Television: Analysis of the Independent Television Service's Documentaries, 2007-2016
Caty Borum Chattoo, Patricia Aufderheide, Michele Alexander, and Chandler Green 647

Against Hollywood: American Independent Film as a Critical Cultural Movement
Sherry B. Ortner. 670

Alternative Media, Self-Representation and Arab-American Women
Kenza Oumlil 689

PART 7: AUDIENCES: PARTICIPATION, ENGAGEMENT, AND ACCESS

Conventions, Computers, and Collective Action (1991-2007)
Francesca Coppa 709

Coming Out as Popular Media Practice: The Politics of Queer Youth Coming Out on YouTube
Sander De Ridder and Frederik Dhaenens 743

Public Value and Participation of Civil Society—A Case for Public Service or Community Media?
Manuela Grünangerl, Josef Trappel, and Corinna Wenzel. 759

Moments of Danger: The Struggle for Community-based Public Radio in Baltimore
Jason Loviglio. 784

Making Media Public: On Revolutionary Street Screenings in Egypt
Nina Grønlykke Mollerup and Sherief Gaber 800

The Death of Indie Hip-Hop?:The Blurry Lines Between the Majors and Independent Hip-Hop
Christopher Vito 815

PART 8: JOURNALISM AND THE PUBLIC

Podcasting as Public Media: The Future of U.S. News, Public Affairs, and Educational Podcasts
Patricia Aufderheide, David Lieberman, Atika Alkhallouf, and Jiji Majiri Ugboma 841

The Future of Public Service Media and the Internet
Alessandra D'Arma, Christian Fuchs, Minna Horowitz, and Klaus Unterberger 861

Community Radio and Peace-building in Kenya
Jessica Gustafsson 871

Intersectionality in Autonomous Journalism Practices
Sandra Jeppesen and Media Action Research Group 887

Amplifying Counter-Public Spheres on Social Media: News Sharing of Alternative Versus Traditional Media After the 2019 Chilean Uprising
Juan Pablo Luna, Sergio Toro, and Sebastián Valenzuelap 906

Iranian Internet Cinema, a Cinema of Embodied Protest: Imperfect, Amateur, Small, Unauthorized, Global
Hamid Naficy 926

Media Representations of Burundi's 2020 Elections in Belgium and Burundi
Caroline Williamson Sinalo 941

Digital Amplification of Fringe Voices: Alternative Media and Street Politics in Hong Kong
Yidong Wang 959

PART 9: COMMUNITY AND LOCALISM

Not Just Surviving but Thriving: Practices That Sustain a New Generation of Latin American Community Media Makers
Diana Coryat 983

Community Media Makers and the Mediation of Difference: Claiming Citizenship and Belongingness
Lola de Koning, Elaine Nolten, and Koen Leurs 999

Failties at the Borders: Stalled Activist Media Projects in East Africa
Christina Dunbar-Hester 1015

Wireless Mesh Networks as Community Hubs: Analysis of Small-Scale Wireless Mesh Networks and Community-Centered Technology Training
Jamie Alexander Greig 1035

'Neither Silent Nor Invisible': Anti-poverty Communication in the San Francisco Bay Area
Dorothy Kidd and Bernadette Barker-Plummer 1063

Core Dimensions of Community Radio in Action: The Case of Ghana
Lawrence Naaikuur and Africanus L. Diedong 1077

Communicative Sovereignty in Latin America: The Case of Radio Mundo Real
Katherine Reilly 1096

Combatting Cultural 'Nerve Gas': Maintaining Traditional Media and Culture through Local Media Production in Australia, Canada and Mexico
Ian Watson 1115

PART 10: NETWORKS AND SOCIAL MEDIA

Activist Networks
Joshua D. Atkinson. 1133

Why Diverse Zines Matter: A Case Study of the People of Color Zines Project
Melanie Ramdarshan Bold 1157

FCJ-193 Harbouring Dissent: Greek Independent and Social Media and the Antifascist Movement
Sky Croeser and Tim Highfield 1172

The Case for Alternative Social Media
Robert W. Gehl 1189

The Opium of the Paquete: State Censorship, Private Self-Censorship, and the Content-Distribution Strategies of Cuba's Emergent, Independent Digital-Media Start-Ups
Ted A. Henken. 1209

Bridging the Open Web and APIs: Alternative Social Media Alongside the Corporate Web
Jack Jamieson, Naomi Yamashita, and Rhonda McEwen 1233

Building Wi-Fi Networks for Communities: Three Canadian Cases
Catherine Middleton and Barbara Crow 1254

PART 11: ACTIVISM AND RESISTANCE

Punks' Jungle: São Paulo
Rodrigo Lopes de Barros 1281

The Lumad Struggle for Social and Environmental Justice: Alternative Media in a Socio-Environmental Movement in the Philippines
Belinda F. Espiritu 1315

Indymedia and the Long Story of Rebellion Against Neoliberal Capitalsim
Natalie Fenton 1332

Bearing Witness to Authoritarianism and Commoning through Video Activism and Political Film-Making after the Gezi Protests
Özge Özdüzen 1339

Alternative Media in Latin American Grassroots Integration: Building Networks and New Agendas
Daniela Parra 1355

Feminist Media as Alternative Media? Theorising Feminist Media from the Perspective of Alternative Media Studies
Jenny Gunnarsson Payne 1374

Media Activism from Above and Below: Lessons From the 1940s American Reform Movement
Victor Pickard. 1390

Queer Blogs and Digital Archives: A Tactical Shift Towards Queer Utopia in Bangladesh
Mohammed Mizanur Rashid 1405

CHAPTER 14

‘In the Waiting Room’: Digitisation and Post-Neoliberalism in Buenos Aires’ Independent Music Sector

Geoff Baker

In *Music and Digital Media: A Planetary Anthropology*, edited by Georgina Born, 90–134. UCL Press, 2022.

Abstract

This chapter analyses the independent music sector in Buenos Aires in the wake of two major developments of the 1990s and early 2000s, digitisation and the national economic crisis of 2001, drawing primarily on fieldwork in 2011–13. The first section outlines the Buenos Aires music industry, focusing on independent labels and artists, and exploring the relative fortunes of the digital content and live music sectors. The second section takes as a case study a small label, ZZK Records, and the genre around which it coalesced, digital *cumbia*, examining the label’s changing relationship to digital technology and its economic strategies. Other strands of digital cumbia production are also considered. The final section explores the role of the state in the field of digitisation and culture. Alongside digitisation, Argentina saw a political transition to centre-left populist governments, and the two became increasingly entwined. The Kirchner governments (2003–15) saw new policies aimed at supporting the independent music sector and, more broadly, the emergence of a post-neoliberal paradigm for the cultural

CC BY-NC

industries that sought to catalyse progressive alternatives to digital capitalism. An ethos of collectivism arose in response to the opportunities and challenges provided by digitisation and post-crisis economic realities. Many related developments came to an abrupt halt with the election of the centre-right candidate Mauricio Macri as president in late 2015.

Introduction

From the turn of the millennium, Buenos Aires emerged as a major centre of electronic dance music (EDM) in Latin America. As well as constituting an important regional hub for international EDM, it was also at the heart of the creation of new styles that reinvented traditional Latin American genres by incorporating digital technology and aesthetics. Argentinean laptop artist-producers mixed Latin American and Caribbean popular and folk musics with electronic genres like techno, dub, dubstep and dancehall to create new hybrid styles—first electro-tango (around 2000) and subsequently digital *cumbia* and digital folklore. Among the main driving forces that fostered the latter genres and propelled them to the global stage was the Buenos Aires label ZZK Records, internationally recognised as an important creative force in contemporary Latin American electronic music.

I was drawn to this area for a number of reasons. *Cumbia*, a genre of Colombian origin that spread across the Americas in the mid-twentieth century, had until recently been somewhat underrepresented in the academic literature, considering its significance in the region.[1] It had been an important feature of working-class musical life in Argentina for some fifty years, and while Argentinean sociologists had paid considerable attention to cumbia villera, with its intimate connection to the neoliberal 1990s and subsequent economic crisis, the music's more recent incorporation and transformation by middle-class laptop producers in Buenos Aires and the emergence of a middle-class cumbia scene had attracted minimal academic attention.[2] These developments seemed worthy of further study, since they pointed to a new phase in the history of this genre, one connected to wider changes in Argentina since the turn of the millennium. The country's decade of neoliberal capitalism, the 1990s, culminated in a catastrophic economic crisis in 2001, ushering in the centre-left Peronist governments of Néstor Kirchner (2003–7) and Cristina Fernández de Kirchner (2007–15). One consequence of the crisis and subsequent turn to nationalist and regionalist politics was increasing identification with Latin America on the part of a middle class that, in Buenos Aires at least, had long been famed for its Europhilia. This significant socio-political transformation was felt in the musical sphere. Rock had exercised a considerable hold over Argentinean audiences since the 1960s: Argentina was a pioneer in the development of rock en español in Latin America and is frequently described in middle-class circles as 'a rock country'. Yet while rock retained considerable popularity, national folkloric musics and internationally circulating Latin American genres such as cumbia were gaining increasing visibility among the middle and upper classes (Sánchez 2014). Digital *cumbia* and folklore thus spoke of wider social, political and cultural transformations, and with ZZK Records foregrounding the digital at the level

[1] The subsequent publication of several books (such as Vila and Semán 2011; Semán and Vila 2011; Fernández L'Hoeste and Vila 2013) altered this picture.

[2] There is an extensive literature on *cumbia villera*, in which the work of Pablo Semán and Pablo Vila has been particularly important. Irisarri 2011 is, however, the only study of digital *cumbia*.

of both musical aesthetics and institutional self-presentation, this label and its genres were potentially fertile terrain for studying the nexus between music, politics and new technologies.

For all the increasing legitimation of *cumbia*, however, ZZK's music was largely divorced from the mainstream *cumbia* or 'tropical music' scene in Buenos Aires, which was dominated by the 'popular' (that is to say working and lower-middle) classes. ZZK was tied more closely to the middle-class indie rock and alternative EDM scenes, illustrating that class divisions subsumed genre connections. During 2011 laptop *cumbia* became established in the commercial *cumbia* scene, due above all to the huge success of the boy band Los Wachiturros, which spawned many imitators and rivals, and a new subgenre—*música turra*. However, it was emblematic of Buenos Aires' class and geographical divides that these distinctive strands of digital *cumbia* barely intersected. This study thus focuses primarily on a niche of middle-class, independent musicians and labels rather than the *cumbia* mainstream, though it also considers *música turra*.[3]

Examining these actors provided insights into the fortunes of a sector of the music industry under digital conditions. The music industry suffered heavily in the aftermath of the 2001 crisis, and while it soon began to recover, it was then subject to many of the challenges experienced at global level with the explosion of internet access. Nevertheless, there were also important continuities: for example, the multinational major labels, long established in Argentina, continued to control over 80 per cent of the record market, and concerts by middle-aged rock stars from the global North filled stadiums. A focus on ZZK Records and related artists sheds light on the uncertain place for independent musicians and new technologies in this picture.

From the start, ZZK's outlook was global. It was co-founded by Grant C. Dull, a North American who had previously created What's Up Buenos Aires, an English-language internet portal for the Buenos Aires cultural scene, and it particularly caught the attention of expats, hip tourists and foreign journalists. Its early and enthusiastic adoption of social media and its aesthetic orientation towards fusions with internationally circulating forms of EDM resulted in prominent participation in the transnational networks of Global (or Tropical) Bass, the digital, club-oriented offspring of World Music (though over time its orientation shifted towards the parent genre). ZZK's artists toured regularly to Europe and the US, and collaborated with producers overseas, and the label signed a licensing deal with Los Angeles label Waxploitation in 2011. ZZK Records was thus a thoroughly, and at times frantically, transnational operation.

As ZZK's centre of attention shifted ever more towards Europe and North America, it became less rooted in the local music scene. In many respects, five years after its foundation ZZK could have been located in Bogotá, Brooklyn or Barcelona, and its location was arguably wherever Grant Dull's laptop happened to be. In order to explore wider issues surrounding music and digitisation that were more specific to Buenos Aires, I therefore broadened my research to encompass developments in cultural and digital policy at municipal, national and continental levels. The Ministry of Culture launched several new initiatives centred on digital transformations and the cultural industries, and seemed set on playing a larger and more supportive role in the independent music sector. Once again, transnationalism

[3] 'Independent' will be used here to refer to music other than *música tropical*, not released by a multinational major label.

was to the fore, and these shifting visions and policies must be understood in the context of the marked Latin American regionalism of the early twenty-first century. While many such initiatives were ultimately abortive, they signalled important shifts in the conceptualisation of the relationship between politics, culture and the digital, on the part of the Argentinean government and of the Latin American Left more generally.

The Buenos Aires music industry in the digital era

According to a report by the Observatorio de Industrias Creativas (OIC) in 2011, the Buenos Aires music industry represented a successful sector of the economy, with its total income having almost doubled between 2005 and 2009 ('La Industria de la Música' 2011). The principal reason for this success was live music, which grew by nearly 300 per cent in that period. These statistics contrasted, however, with a more uneven picture emanating from the city's independent music scenes. On 4 June 2012, the Club Cultural Matienzo hosted a debate on the topic: 'From underground to indie: industry and venues in the waiting room', which provided a snapshot of the independent music sector at the time. Participants complained of small audiences, a lack of venues and meagre earnings. The alleged cause of this difficult situation was new technologies: the internet was seen as a rival to live music, responsible for an excess of music and a dearth of audiences. One older musician quipped that if his generation wanted to hear music and meet girls, they used to go to gigs; now people stayed at home with YouTube and chat. The messages conveyed by the panellists were: work hard, lower your expectations and question whether you are good enough. It was hard to imagine that the audience went away with renewed hope.

A closer reading of the OIC report reveals two important findings that support the more negative mood seen at the debate. First, the growth of live music covered up a big drop in the sales of physical formats, yet the drop had not been offset by rising digital sales, which accounted for just 7 percent of total music sales in 2009, compared to a Latin American average of 15 per cent ('La Industria de la Música' 2011, 45–6). The report concluded that 'the digital market is not being consolidated in Argentina' (2011, 42). Furthermore, the limited digital sales were concentrated among overseas consumers and fans of Top Ten artists, meaning there was almost no local digital market for independent music.

Digital distribution initiatives by Argentine record and telecoms companies had been broadly unsuccessful. There had been several attempts to launch portals, from 2005 to 2007, but none had prospered and some had closed again. There were six portals active in 2010, but the number of users appeared to be low. The failure of Zap Música, launched in 2005, was emblematic: despite major investment from the cable company Fibertel, the portal achieved only derisory sales *(never exceeding $400 a month)*. The mobile music market was also slow to take off in Argentina and, at least initially, had a negligible effect on the independent music sphere, since mobile phone operators focused on selling a small range of current hits. iTunes launched in Argentina in 2011, but only 0.5 per cent of the population used it in 2013 ('Encuesta Nacional' 2013).

With the pay-per-download model showing few signs of promise, commercial attention shifted to streaming. Multinational services Grooveshark and Deezer launched in Argentina and 2012 saw the creation of the Buenos Aires-based Taringa! Música. Its parent company,

Taringa!, founded in 2005, was not only a highly successful social network but a prime source of links to free downloads of music, films and books and the first stop for music producers in search of pirated software, samples and plug-ins. Initially seen as a local equivalent of Megaupload, the Hong Kong-based file hosting service shut down by the FBI in 2012, it went through a tortuous legal process for several years from 2009. Its owners, the brothers Matías and Hernán Botbol and Alberto Nakayama, were committed for trial in 2012, charged with violating Argentina's intellectual property law by facilitating copyright infringement ('Confirman juicio oral' 2012). This was to be the first public trial in Argentina in which the responsibility of websites for the illegal actions of their end users would be debated, and Taringa! became a focal point for local debates about IP.

As part of efforts to legitimise its activities under the shadow of the impending trial, the company launched Taringa! Música, a legal streaming service. In 2012–13, it negotiated with multinational major labels, and trade and collecting societies, principally SADAIC (Argentinean Society of Authors and Music Composers) and CAPIF (Argentinean Chamber of Phonogram and Videogram Producers), and now described its aim as to become the Spotify of the Spanish-speaking world. The possibility that Taringa! Música might offer a radical alternative to the commercial digital distribution platforms of the global North receded as it backed off from a 'free culture'-esque stance under pressure to deal with major industry and legal institutions. By September 2013 Taringa!'s counter-cultural discourse had all but vanished: Hernán Botbol described a company that had attempted to respect IP norms and deal with complaints from rights holders while operating in an ill-defined legislative context, and had been unfairly treated by publishers. [4]

Late 2013 also saw a major blow for Taringa! Música—the arrival of Spotify in Argentina. While the Argentinean company had been embroiled in drawn-out negotiations, it had been outflanked by an international competitor and its moment had passed. Features of Taringa! Música that had been innovative when it was conceived were now commonplace on multinational services like Spotify and SoundCloud, and a combination of Argentinean fascination with foreign trends and the negative associations of the Taringa! brand put the local alternative at a disadvantage. Furthermore, Taringa!'s directors, observing the finances of multinational services, became less convinced by the idea of music streaming as an economic venture. With Taringa! Música just one part of a larger enterprise, and a problematic one at that, the directors shifted their attention to other areas, redesigning the portal as a source of information for news media. Taringa!'s attempts to improve its image had been largely successful—by agreeing to publishers' demands, it had ensured that the legal case against it was all but dropped ('Otro querellante' 2014)—but the sense that its music service might challenge multinational enterprises had passed. In 2013, only 3.8 per cent of the population used it to listen to or download music, compared to 27.5 per cent for the peer-to-peer service Ares and 14.4 per cent for YouTube ('Encuesta Nacional' 2013). With none of these services generating direct income for independent musicians, there was no immediate sign that digitised music would provide a financial lifeline to the independent music sector.

The second important finding of the OIC report was that 80 per cent of live Argentine music revenue came from stadium concerts. The local music industry thus depended heavily

[4] http://lic.cultura.gob.ar/foros-de-cultura-digital. No longer available.

on big-name acts, particularly international stars. Accounting for 90 per cent of the concert promotion market in 2012, the promotion and production companies T4F-Time for Fun, Fénix and Pop Art—rather than digital content providers—emerged as the primary actors of the music industry in the digital era ('El background' 2012). Many large concerts were sponsored by major brands and the early 2000s saw the rise of sponsored festivals such as Pepsi Music Festival (originally Quilmes Rock, founded in 2003) and Personal Fest (from 2004). The music industry boom thus exemplified the continuing concentration and corporatisation of the cultural industries, a process noted in the 1980s (Hesmondhalgh 2012) that has only intensified under digital conditions. In Argentina, as in the global North (Netto 2012), music was generating capital at an industry level above even that of the multinational major labels, with its value now lying primarily in its capacity to sell the products and services of the consumer electronics and telecoms industries.

The propitious local conditions for international rock stars were highlighted when Roger Waters sold 372,550 tickets for nine shows as part of his 'The Wall Live' tour, making the River Plate football stadium the second most important open-air venue in the world in 2012 from the perspective of ticket sales (Kantor 2013). Waters personally earned $15.7 million, illustrating how Buenos Aires' '2.0' music industry was primarily benefitting the same musicians who thrived under the '1.0' version, with profits concentrating at the top end of the live music industry. The digital era saw Buenos Aires experiencing a form of rock imperialism from the global North, boosted by the recession in Europe ('El background' 2012). Argentina's large rock fan base provided a receptive audience: 'The high demand for tickets makes Buenos Aires one of the most important markets on the planet', claimed Waters' agent (Kantor 2013).

This was a promising picture for transnational corporations and international stars, but less so for local independent musicians. Indeed, the OIC report noted 'impoverishment of the local, alternative scene' ('La Industria de la Música' 2011, 47) as fans' expenditure was drawn away from mid-level local artists in favour of international touring acts. Exacerbating the problem was a shortage of suitable small- and medium-sized venues, after a fire at the nightclub República Cromañón in 2004, which killed nearly 200 people, led the city government to close locales and tighten licensing practices. A decade after the tragedy, the city government continued to shut down small-scale cultural centres.[5] Independent musicians and promoters lamented the lack of performance spaces, the bureaucratic hurdles to creating new ones, the prevalence of shady practices in existing ones, and the struggles simply to break even (see also Totah 2014). One, DJ Relo, explained how he had founded Sub Klub netlabel as a response to the declining opportunities for live events; the internet provided an alternative outlet for his musical energies and an escape from the problems of the urban environment. Independent musicians thus found themselves in a double bind: declining sales of recordings raised the importance of live performance, yet the urban infrastructure and restrictive regulations conspired against it.

Independent labels were unsurprisingly downbeat in their outlook. Their problems were a decade old, to judge from an OIC report in 2004 that asked: 'How do small and medium independent labels survive, if even in an optimistic scenario the profits made from recording and releasing records are practically nil?' ('La industria del disco' 2004, 74). The first answer

[5] http://leymeca.com.ar. No longer available.

was that many labels had not survived. Those that had were increasingly distancing themselves from content creation, tending more towards licensing existing music. At a debate at the cultural industries trade fair MICA in 2013, one label owner proposed dropping the first word in the term 'record label', since labels rarely made records anymore. Another claimed that small labels were increasingly operating as a service industry, offering distribution to musicians for a fixed fee; some did not even have their own catalogue. He suggested that there was little investment in music at any level of the industry since it was simply no longer profitable to produce music in a studio.

If digital optimists have argued that the internet is democratising the cultural industries (see Hesmondhalgh 2012, 313–21), these independent label owners were more sceptical, pointing to their straitened circumstances and those of their musicians. One asked rhetorically: 'Who is going to protect us in this monstrous digital world, abandoned to the market as it is, perhaps more so than the record industry ever was?' Nicolás Falcoff, owner of the independent label Sura, claimed that there was 'a hyper concentration, a hyper monopolisation hiding behind the curtain of the democratisation of content on the internet'. Major corporations were profiting handsomely while 'those who are losing the battle are the content producers'. He described corporations as acting like parasites on cultural producers rather than investing revenues back into new production, resulting in the concentration of profits—a view echoed by academic reports on the global industry (for example Leurdijk and Nieuwenhuis 2012, 10). The evidence from Buenos Aires that revenue was not trickling back down to the independent music sector in a consistent way was echoed elsewhere: Solís (2010) reports a similar scenario in Santiago de Chile, while the Digital Music Report (2011, 22), describing 'the squeeze on the smaller players' around the world, provides a downbeat picture of losses and declining investment in artists on the part of labels in the UK and Mexico as well as Argentina.

The production of stasis in the Buenos Aires music economy

According to the Club Cultural Matienzo debate, the independent industry was 'in the waiting room'—a phrase that captures the sense of inertia and uncertainty in the sector at that time. One factor behind this stasis was the slow development of a digital music economy in Argentina. This in turn relates to the lack of credit card penetration and confidence in online transactions, in part a consequence of the central role of banks in the 2001 crisis and thus a limited culture of e-commerce. Moreover, not least thanks to Taringa!, there was a deeply rooted culture of free downloading, which was considered 'cool', according to Zap Música's former director: 'Buying in Zap Música was not cool. You were stupid if you bought it, because you could go to many sites and download it for free. So why pay?' The culture of internet use in Buenos Aires combined widespread access and high technological literacy with a disinterest in paying for digital content and pervasive 'free culture' practices. In 2012, the US-based International Intellectual Property Alliance (IIPA) painted a picture of high rates of piracy and low enforcement, and kept Argentina on its Priority Watch List (Argentina 2012). The IP activist Lila Pagola (2010, 40) wrote: 'We are copyleft avant la lettre, simply because if there were not a generalized practice of unauthorized copying and peer-to-peer sharing, the majority of us would not have access to cultural goods.'

While Argentineans' reluctance to buy digital content dampened optimism about the future of digital distribution, institutional forces must also be taken into account. The multinational major labels, the local collecting and trade societies SADAIC, CAPIF and AADI (the Argentinean Association of Performers) and the mainstream media formed a close and collusive bloc which had historically exerted a strong hold over the music industry. Many interlocutors traced the stasis in the digital music field to the attitudes and actions of these dominant players, which were widely regarded as having taken a conservative line with regard to emerging digital conditions: slow to react and fighting to defend their territory rather than adapting.

During the 1990s, the majors bought up large independent labels, as they did across Latin America (Ochoa and Yudice 2002; 'Valor y símbolo' 2010, 86). According to the OIC's 2004 report, the majors had 82.6 per cent of the national market, giving Argentina the second highest penetration of foreign capital in Latin America ('La industria del disco' 2004, 46). In 2010 the majors had 80 per cent of the record market and 90 per cent of the top-selling albums in Argentina ('Valor y símbolo' 2010). In the early 2000s, however, the majors streamlined their operations in Latin America (Laing 2009, 23). The 2004 report claimed that the major labels had suspended their research and development of new artists and were focusing on promoting a small number of long-established figures. The majors thus fostered a rigid and conservative star system, making opportunities for new entrants scarce. In Argentina, as elsewhere (Elavsky 2013, 105–6; Leurdijk and Nieuwenhuis 2012, 46), less famous national artists took the brunt of cutbacks as the majors reduced investment and focused on marketing global priority artists. In one analysis, a combination of the domination of the majors and the abandonment of policies in support of local industries during the neoliberal wave of the 1980s and 90s impeded the development of the Latin American music industry (Barrowclough and Kozul-Wright 2011, 21; Cunningham et al. 2011, 75). In the early 2000s, I would argue, the majors' simultaneous strength (in terms of market share) and weakness (in terms of the general decline of the recording industry) led them to take a cautious line, producing retrenchment rather than dynamic new developments. By 2012 the major record companies' Argentinean offices were increasingly diversifying into 'new business', negotiating with streaming services, concert producers and brands and transforming themselves into content and entertainment companies. Nevertheless, due to their earlier recalcitrance, they were still widely perceived as a conservative force.

Founded in 1936 and 1958 respectively, SADAIC and CAPIF, too, were commonly viewed as sources of inertia, resisting attempts to reshape intellectual property policies for the digital era and labouring over negotiations with digital initiatives such as Taringa! Música. SADAIC was commonly described as a conservative institution run by elderly men—'a white elephant' with 'a very analogue way of thinking', in the words of one senior industry figure. The same individual said of AADI: 'I talk about digital to them, and they make a very big effort, but they don't get it. They don't use it, so they don't get it.' A state cultural official described these institutions as 'the analogue sector', claiming that they made little effort to grasp how digitisation was reshaping the cultural sphere.

Relations between the major labels and the collecting and trade societies were tight: the majors dominated CAPIF (Lamacchia 2012, 142–4), while SADAIC's opaque and much criticised formula for dividing up royalty income was said to favour the multinationals. The majors also had privileged access to the mainstream media, which continued to be important

in Argentina (Becerra, Marino and Mastrini 2012, 18; 'La industria del disco' 2004, 29). Radio play was still key to music consumption ('Encuesta nacional' 2013) and industry success, and independent musicians claimed that payola was rife, making it hard for them to gain exposure. While the 2009 media law (Ley de Servicios de Comunicación Audiovisual) was supposed to redress this balance by stipulating a quota for local independent music, the digital era had not yet seen a significant shake-up of the main players of the Argentinean recorded music industry, whose continuing collusive dominance left limited space for innovation.

If the institutional panorama was dominated by defensive, analogue-era organisations, institutional and political divisions also contributed to the production of stasis. The national and municipal cultural industries offices were run by opposing political parties and pursued divergent policies, while the major labels had limited connections with these offices and the independent sector. The majors operated to a significant degree as a separate sphere, their institutional line and much of their catalogue determined overseas. Such was the separation between the majors and the rest in neighbouring Brazil that Howard-Spink *(2006)* argued that there were effectively two recording industries. In sum, Buenos Aires sustained a fragmented and contested music sector, and as the fate of Zap Música and Taringa! Música confirmed, this was an unpropitious setting for aspirant digital music entrepreneurs.

ZZK Records and digital cumbias

ZZK Records, founded by Grant C. Dull, Diego Bulacio (aka Villa Diamante) and Guillermo Canale (aka DJ Nim), began life in 2006 as a weekly club night, coalesced into a label in 2008 and by 2011 had evolved into an integrated management and production company housing nine artists plus the three founder-DJs. Its parties brought together laptop artists interested in fusing Latin American musics with international genres like techno, dancehall and dub. It coined the term 'digital *cumbia*' for its signature sound, an EDM-tinged version of the Colombian genre adopted by Argentina; but a number of ZZK artists showed equal or greater affinity for Argentinean folkloric musics.

ZZK's artists had considerable interest in national and continental traditions, yet they and their audiences were primarily middle- to upper-middle-class cosmopolitans with a notable orientation towards the global North. The scene that coalesced around them amounted to a 'culture of circulation' (Baker 2015a; Lee and LiPuma 2002). Two of its foundational figures were a Dutch conceptual artist and musician, Dick Verdult aka Dick el Demasiado, and a North American DJ, Gavin Burnett aka Oro11. Dick el Demasiado's Festicumex (Festival of Experimental Cumbias) in 2003 was a prime catalyst, and Burnett, who spent an extended period in Buenos Aires in the early 2000s, further opened the ears of upper-middle-class tastemakers to fusions of *cumbia* with hip hop, dub and reggae. ZZK cofounder and manager Grant Dull had previously cofounded the website What's Up Buenos Aires (WUBA), aimed at connecting foreign audiences with the Buenos Aires cultural sphere. The scene was thus initiated by the circulation of foreign musicians through Buenos Aires, consolidated by a North American cultural entrepreneur and 'ignored by most locals but eagerly embraced by first-world expats living in Buenos Aires'.[6]

[6] http://latinbutcool.blogspot.co.uk/2008/03/enter-cumbia-phenomenon.html Invitation only.

I was originally attracted to study ZZK Records because of its international renown but also because it seemed to embody a cutting-edge, distinctively digital enterprise. Like many ethnographers of the digital, I faced fundamental challenges when I began fieldwork, such as where and what to study. ZZK artists played prestigious festivals and the label was covered by international media outlets, yet its impressive web presence contrasted with a local operation that consisted largely of Dull, his assistant Allie Silver, and their laptops. For much of my fieldwork ZZK did not have an office and work often took place in living rooms, bedrooms and cafés. Dull would spend much of his day networking digitally with the outside world—writing and answering emails and posting news, videos and music on social media. As a result, ZZK and its technologically savvy musicians became a key point of reference for the transnational Global Bass scene. Paradoxically, though, their local presence in Buenos Aires was far more modest.

Digital *cumbia* was more coherent on the internet than in the online world. Emerging from different points in Latin America in the early 2000s, its central nodes became Facebook or SoundCloud groups like 'The New Cumbia Makers' and blogs like 'Generation Bass', 'Nu *Cumbia* Experience' and 'Cassette Blog'.[7] If more traditional forms of *cumbia* were the soundtrack to countless large dances every weekend, digital *cumbia* was surprisingly elusive on the streets of Latin American cities and primarily inhabited online spaces.

ZZK was indeed a highly digital enterprise in 2011–12. It had a colourful website and its artists were assiduous users of social media.[8] They made mixtapes—consisting of their own unreleased tracks, their remixes of other artists' work and others' remixes of theirs—which the label distributed for free on its website.[9] As well as disseminating current information, Dull often filled quiet news days with retrospective posts—old videos of key performances from the past, for example—thereby constructing and reinforcing a sense of institutional history. Though remaining a niche label, ZZK created a transnational fan base via the internet and its artists communicated extensively with listeners and other producers, both locally and overseas. While Buenos Aires' musical culture has been notably transnational for centuries, its circulatory flows and international profile were much intensified by the internet.

At the same time, with industry developments moving fast, I was obliged to reconsider my initial premise about ZZK's distinctiveness. It might have been an accurate assessment earlier in ZZK's history: Dull had contacts and a knowledge of social media that helped bring ZZK's parties and then the label to international prominence in its first phase. But by 2012, to describe ZZK as a distinctively digital enterprise seemed increasingly meaningless. After the rapid international spread of a handful of dominant platforms, there was now little that distinguished ZZK's digital tools and strategy from those of myriad other independent labels, both locally and overseas. The intensification of circulation enabled by the web promoted certain kinds of standardisation on the web, which was further reinforced by the proliferation of homogenised, user-friendly internet tools; online presentations of self were thus increasingly similar.

---

[7] https://www.facebook.com/groups/Cumbiamakers. Accessed 9 January 2022. www.generationbass.com; http://nucumbiaexperience.com. No longer available. www.cassetteblog.com. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[8] http://zzkrecords.com. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[9] http://zzkrecords.com/mixtapes. Accessed 9 January 2022.

What was striking about ZZK by 2012 was less its digital practices than the fact that its artists were starting to turn away from their original one-man-and-his-laptop formula and instead constitute ensembles, incorporate 'real' instruments and play down sampling. By this point, with digital technology now so commonplace in Buenos Aires, what was distinctive about ZZK was less a digital ethos than a post-digital one (Baker 2015b). The prefix 'post-' signifies modification, self-reflexivity and critique rather than rupture, since digital technology continued to be widely used. If there was a temporal aspect, it described a putative moment after digital saturation, a state of affairs evoked by Villa Diamante's 2009 mash-up album *Empacho digital* (Digital indigestion).

Most of ZZK's artists came from an EDM background and in ZZK's earlier phases, the digital had played an important role in mediating cumbia for the upper-middle class, who had historically viewed this genre as vulgar for its strong association with the 'popular' classes. Digital fusion enacted a class move, making this music not just acceptable but positively hip. However, as *cumbia* gained space among the middle classes, a process that accelerated with the appearance of middle-class 'traditional' *cumbia* orchestras from around 2009, several ZZK artists began to see their music-making as a personal journey into Latin American traditions, one that involved more sparing or self-critical use of new technologies and deeper engagement with old ones. Consequently, the laptop lost some ground to traditional instruments and a more conspicuously live aesthetic. Whereas in the peripheral Mexican city of Tijuana, the digital fusion musicians of the Nortec Collective aspired to modernity and cosmopolitanism (Madrid 2008), ZZK's artists were based in a capital city that had long been one of the most modern and cosmopolitan in Latin America. Their search was in the opposite direction: an inward turn, towards a different kind of connectedness, in this case to indigenous cultures and to nature. If, according to Alejandro Madrid, Nortec's 'savvy' musicians were driven largely by career and economic concerns and approached local culture through the prism of kitsch, ZZK's were more serious, even romantic, in their efforts to study Latin American traditions and merge them with urban cosmopolitanism, and this increasing engagement with such traditions entailed rethinking their relationship to digital technologies.

Initially, the computer had been central to ZZK's aesthetic; now, five years later, it was being literally and figuratively moved into the background whenever possible. Leo Martinelli started out working solo with a laptop, and then added two musicians (playing analogue synthesiser and acoustic drum) to form Tremor.[10] Chancha Vía Circuito started by sampling indigenous music on his computer; then he remixed a traditional song, 'Pintar el sol', sung by Miriam García and Alicia Solans, for his album *Rio Arriba*; finally he started taking folkloric music lessons with García.[11] The two musicians eventually performed together in public, singing duets—including 'Pintar el sol'—accompanied only by hand-held frame drums.[12] In 2011, El Remolón, also a solo laptop artist, added three musicians to form El Remolón y Su Conjunto, and he launched his albums *Boxeo Constitución* (2013) with a seven-piece ensemble and *Selva* (2014) with an acoustic set.[13] ZZK's newest and highest-profile signing, La Yegros,

[10] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=dRDbttlaZQw. No longer available.

[11] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9CAzSMAqS10. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[12] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XPO-MT6zkiI. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[13] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eY7SVqfS7q0. Accessed 9 January 2022.

performed with a full band; a laptop was tucked discreetly away at the back. The last three artists were now capable of performing without laptop and even without electricity.

For such artists, musical evolution or progression involved a kind of technological regression. Digital technology, rather than being the end point of a development from tradition to modernity, and from acoustic to analogue to digital, served as a starting point for a journey back to roots—from the modern to the traditional, the foreign to the local, the electronic to the acoustic—and from solo to interactive music-making. Villa Diamante's phrase 'digital indigestion' sums up a scene in which artists, while continuing to use digital technology, were developing increasingly critical perspectives towards it, ever more aware of its limitations as well as its advantages.

ZZK's post-digital shift had multiple causes. One was the emergence of a research ethos that bordered on amateur ethnomusicology or anthropology. Having begun by sampling folkloric music, several artists became more interested in their sources and saw learning to play or sing this music as a logical next step in their musical development, even travelling to other parts of the continent to hone their skills and collect music and instruments. They sought a more direct experience than sampling—playing the music themselves or working with musicians who did. This turn to sources was underpinned by the growing identification with Latin America on the part of Buenos Aires' traditionally Eurocentric middle class in the post-crisis period. Another reason for this shift related to copyright. After signing a management deal with Los Angeles-based Waxploitation in 2011, ZZK's releases had to comply with US copyright law, which meant all samples had to be cleared legally. The complexity and expense of this process meant that artists subsequently preferred to play or sing the music themselves, or expand into a band format. A third factor was the increasing economic importance of live performance (and thus of a sense of 'liveness') in an era of declining sales of recordings. A band format was considered more appealing to audiences and bookers, particularly in the crucial European summer festival market (see below). In sum, ZZK's 'early adopters' had developed a more complex relationship with the digital by 2012. A post-digital frame underlines this evolving vision and treats the enthusiastic embrace of the digital as a historical phase rather than an end point.

The economics of ZZK Records

ZZK's history was marked by a search for a viable business model. While it began as a weekly club night, by 2011–12 its live performances took place only sporadically. Its events rarely generated significant income and sometimes operated at a loss. After several years, ZZK's founders were no longer willing to invest the necessary time and energy in unprofitable live shows. Dull reported: 'How does a label survive month to month? It doesn't. That's the answer. We added up all the money we have coming up from local shows. It's a quarter of the money that we need to keep the label going in Argentina.'

From the start ZZK had an international orientation, organising tours in North America and Europe. These tours generated international publicity, but again they produced little in the way of profit, particularly as some artists had to take time off from day jobs. One early European tour earned the musicians around €400 each. Though there were occasional well-paid gigs and earnings rose as artists became more established, such musicians repeatedly

described overseas touring as more about promotion, contacts and personal interest than income. A commonplace assumption in the digital era is that musicians invest in recording in order to profit through touring; but touring may be characterised as much by investment as revenue generation, illustrating a process of constant deferral of economic rewards (Johnston 2012). The gains of touring are often immaterial, taking the form of cultural and symbolic rather than economic capital. ZZK's directors and investors were clearly frustrated by the disjuncture between prestige and financial returns.

Some of ZZK's albums received very positive reviews in the international press, with NPR proclaiming at the end of 2011 that 'Mati Zundel is about to become a household name among music lovers in the US'. Actual sales of his album *Amazónico Gravitante* were low, however. ZZK's album sales brought in a steady trickle of income, but not enough to provide a solid platform for the business, and even investment in overseas marketing by Waxploitation made little impact on this picture.

With ZZK struggling to generate significant revenue from live music and recordings, it looked increasingly to other sources. While commissions to remix other labels' or artists' work—such as *La Revancha en Cumbia*, an album of remixes of Gotan Project's hugely successful 2001 album La Revancha del Tango—brought in additional income, the key to survival was synchronisations (syncs).[14] Indeed, ZZK decided to license its catalogue to Waxploitation in the hope of capitalising on the latter's contacts and securing syncs with films, TV shows and advertising in the US. Syncs for a Mati Zundel track on an Aerolíneas Argentinas advertisement and for a Frikstailers track with K-Mart brought in five-figure sums in 2012–13, providing a crucial lifeline to both artists and label. Two Zundel tracks, 'Por el Pueblo' and 'El Alto de La Paz', were synced to the TV programme 'Homeland' in 2013, and La Yegros' song 'El Bendito' was synced to the video game 'EA Sports 2014 FIFA World Cup Brazil'.[15] Nevertheless, placing syncs at the centre of financial strategy was risky. 'It's like waving a wand', admitted Dull. 'You can't depend on it. It's a one in a million shot.' Zundel's first sync came about after a friend of Dull's picked up the track from Facebook while 'messing around' with the preview of a commercial that he was making.

Chancha Vía Circuito's experiences illustrated the rewards and challenges of looking for syncs. In 2012, he looked set to license a track to a major US TV show, which would have constituted his and ZZK's biggest financial coup to date. The deal fell through at the final hurdle, however, because the transnational media corporation behind the show insisted on the artist signing away DVD rights, and while both he and ZZK were willing to comply (believing that the fee and TV royalties justified the agreement), SADAIC refused to sign off the agreement, arguing that it was exploitative. A year after this major blow, however, Chancha secured a sync on the hit US TV show 'Breaking Bad'. The song soon had half a million hits on YouTube.

[14] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=awR63tm-O5A&list=PL728126CAF0D66B92. Accessed 9 January 2022. Synchronisations (syncs) involve the licensing of music for addition to video media content.

[15] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pHkzRyQi2dM.
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Yjow4fibUuA.
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5AnuawYM9mg.
Accessed 9 January 2022.

Dull described the first Zundel sync as 'literally the salvation of our year', underlining just how fragile the company's finances were, despite its international reputation. Indeed, when I first contacted Dull, he replied:

> Ninety per cent of what you see ZZK doing I run from my humble apartment/HQ … Survival is as important to us as growth is right now. Ship constantly sinking. Then floating somehow … Don't let the fancy graphics and world tours fool you, we're in constant crisis and hustling like crazy to keep it going.

ZZK's predicament underlined the difficulty in converting intangible assets like prestige, which are relatively easy to acquire in the era of social media, into economic sustainability. Dull's day-to-day struggles made the challenges for independent labels abundantly clear. Thanks to digital technologies, starting a label was easy—but making it economically sustainable was a different matter. In our final interview, Dull began: 'Just write the chapter now—it starts with "We're broke, period".' Later on he recounted a conversation with Jeff Antebi at Waxploitation: 'We asked him yesterday, when does ZZK start to make money? The answer was, maybe never. And it's true. Labels are honestly … I don't know how they exist.'

As Ochoa and Botero (2009) observed in Colombia, they exist through a mix of economies of sacrifice, gift and exchange, alongside more standard industry models. Dull argued that the informality of Buenos Aires' economy meant that a considerable amount of work could be done through favours from friends, at discounted rates, or in exchange for a reciprocal service. ZZK was also cross-subsidised in various ways by its directors' portfolios of activities, and this seemed to be typical for small independent labels (see also Strachan 2007). Dull reported, 'I don't think any of the small or designer labels are making money. I think they do it because they love the music—first and foremost that's the reason I do it too—and they all have other jobs.' Dull continued to run WUBA and took on other marketing work; Villa Diamante had a successful DJ career; Nim ran a graphic design business.

Most musicians that I met cross-subsidised their art from other activities—a scenario typical of independent musicians in other countries (see Frith, Cloonan and Williamson 2009; Madrid 2008; Woodside Woods, Jiménez López and Urteaga 2012; Pereira de Sá and Oliveira Miranda 2012). Among ZZK and similar artists, some opted to cross-subsidise from other kinds of musical activity (and therefore live predominantly from music), while others preferred to work in a completely separate field (and thus keep their art 'pure'). DJing and music teaching were the most common choices. Frikstailers, Leo Martinelli and Axel Krygier wrote music for advertising and films, Gaby Kerpel (King Coya) for theatre (including De la Guarda and Fuerza Bruta), Daleduro for video games and Catnapp for gyms. El Remolón was a psychiatrist, while close ZZK collaborator Miss Bolivia has worked as a psychologist, yoga teacher and journalist.

Despite their limited income, many musicians displayed a non-profit brand of entrepreneurialism. An alternative or countercultural ethos was widespread in the city's independent music scenes, which drew on a historical anti-establishment vein in independent rock. This genre was strongly associated with resistance to the military dictatorship in the 1970s and 80s, and there remains today a nostalgic attachment to this 'golden age' of *rock nacional*. With the 2001 crisis, neoliberal capitalism was widely discredited and new social movements strengthened, consolidating a countercultural outlook among many young, middle-class

Argentineans. The independent popular music sector was thus traversed by the ideologies of post-neoliberal new social movements as well as independent rock, producing a cultural field in which corporations were often viewed askance, independence was valorised and anti-establishment or hippy subjectivities were commonplace.

ZZK Records was a case in point. Its two Argentinean directors were open about their dislike of the business aspect of running a label. Several of ZZK's musicians were uncomfortable with the label's partnership with Waxploitation, despite the latter's international prestige, because it obliged the label to become more business-like. ZZK Records generally styled itself as a collective, having emerged from a tightly-knit underground scene and a club night in which musical collaborations were encouraged. Villa Diamante described its defining characteristic as '*buena onda*' (good vibes), insisting that it prioritised collaboration and the collective good: 'The truth about the label is that … we never thought about it as a way to make money, but rather as a way to … join forces with artists who we thought were interesting … When you see the whole business structure of ZZK and compare it with a real business structure, it's not a business, it's something else, it's a cooperative'.

Villa Diamante and three partners opened the record shop Mercurio Disquería in 2012. His aims were twofold: to support the local independent music scene and not to lose money. Rather than supplement his meagre earnings from ZZK, he deliberately took on another unprofitable venture. He took a certain pride in recounting his counter-intuitive decision to open a record label when record labels were going out of business and a record shop when record shops were closing down. Meanwhile, digital musicians joined online groups like New Cumbia Makers and produced and uploaded their music for free, or created netlabels like Cabeza and SubKlub, or started online radio shows; more than generating profit, these activities required investment. Digital technologies allowed artists to inhabit the music scene in a variety of roles but also with a variety of relationships to the business of music. In the Buenos Aires independent scene, there was a vein of digital amateurism that saw individuals actively opting for non-monetised or non-profitable musical activities and accumulating cultural and symbolic (more than economic) capital in the form of internet likes, plays and free downloads. They were critical of entrepreneurialism when oriented towards business, yet engaged with it enthusiastically in small-scale enterprises with a non-profit ethos.

Disintermediation? ZZK in transnational context

Grant Dull described the birth of ZZK Records as almost an accidental move by three inexperienced friends. However, consolidating the enterprise had required them to engage with the established music industry in the global North and to learn to play by its rules. 'New technology, old structures' was his pithy summary and a corrective to a digital utopianism that fails to account fully for the maintenance of many elements of the 'old' music industry and the resources required to engage with them.

Economic opportunities for 'global' genres were still concentrated in the World Music industry and above all summer festivals, especially those in Europe, which were the growth area of the World Music market (Laing 2009, 28). Ambitious Latin American artists and labels like ZZK targeted this circuit, and securing enough dates to put on a European summer tour was a prime ambition and measure of success. The newer Global Bass scene thus appeared

to serve more as a gateway into the structures of the old industry than a replacement (Marshall 2010). If ZZK started out as a collective of independent laptop artists, a characteristic digital-era phenomenon, its biggest success was provided by La Yegros, a singer backed by two songwriters and a full band whose sound might be characterised as folkloric music given a contemporary flavour with digital beats and effects. La Yegros' breakthrough occurred when her single 'Viene de Mi' was heavily rotated on the French station Radio Nova, resulting in her signing to EMI France in 2013 and touring Europe with her band—hardly a distinctively 2.0 picture.[16] The following year, Dull pointed to her three-month, fifty-date summer festival tour as evidence that her career had taken off (Erbar 2014). However, other musicians from the digital *cumbia* scene noted drily that her success represented a backwards step: from the figure of the experimental electronic music artist to that of the old-fashioned World Music star.

There were also signs that ZZK's self-presentation had shifted somewhat. In the trailer for a documentary about 'Viene de Mi', the label's signature digital technology was nowhere to be seen, replaced by traditional drums and exotic-looking costumes.[17] At Womex in 2012, ZZK described itself as 'reviving Latin American folkloric traditions through an electronic pulse', a subtle reversal of emphasis for a collective whose roots lay primarily in EDM. Despite its initial digital focus, ZZK's biggest coup was via the artist who was furthest from its laptop-music roots and adhered most closely to the old World Music industry's aesthetic paradigms, and the label's updated self-framing suggests a recognition that the surest route to success lay in deferring to old structures rather than stressing new technology.

ZZK's experiences suggested that disintermediation—the marginalisation of middlemen, as musicians use the internet to take more control over their work—was less marked than is sometimes supposed (e.g. Cottrell 2010, 19). If some traditional middlemen were indeed declining in importance, others, such as bookers, promoters, agents and publicists, were rising; the field of intermediaries was thus being reconfigured rather than removed (Baym 2010). For example, a small label owner, Pablo Martín Fernández, explained that he had to go through an aggregator like Tunecore or CD Baby in order to place his music on Spotify or iTunes. Many independent musicians did not understand the process, so they turned to people like him to help them. He thus saw a proliferation of intermediaries, with three filters (Fernández, Tunecore, iTunes) between musicians and their audiences. Meanwhile, for many artists from the global South with international ambitions, industry rules had not changed substantially: while they availed themselves of the new digital tools for publicity and marketing, they also needed the services of agents in the global North in order to insert themselves into established commercial circuits—new technology *and* old structures.

Evidence from Argentina thus supported Rogers' (2013, 151) contention that disintermediation is a limited phenomenon since 'the process of breaking an artist on a wider stage remains largely filtered through many of the same channels as in the pre-internet era.' The challenge facing musicians was less producing or distributing music than promoting it and booking gigs. Dull argued: 'To give great shows, you need a great agent and you need a great management team.' ZZK worked with a complex network of intermediaries on three continents. To break into the US or European market it needed to have the ear of promoters and journalists; agents and publicists—traditional intermediaries who already had the attention of

[16] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WtsjrvwqIr0. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[17] http://vimeo.com/68851466. Accessed 9 January 2022.

these key players and could provide privileged access to old industry networks—were therefore important. At its own cost, ZZK attended major international trade fairs like Womex and SXSW, looking to network and impress industry intermediaries such as European and North American promoters and bookers looking for acts. A key part of Waxploitation's investment in ZZK was temporarily to pay $3000 per month to a press agency in the US, illustrating the kind of real money moving around behind the digital free-for-all of social media.

While it is undeniable that musicians have greater opportunities to take control over their careers than in the past, they are also taking on more tasks (Leurdijk and Nieuwenhuis 2012, 63). In the music business, as in the wider 'creative economy', labour, costs, risks and pressures once assumed by institutions are now increasingly outsourced to individuals, dressed up as flexibility, independence and control. Among my interlocutors, younger musicians with few attachments or responsibilities often enjoyed this freedom, but those who were a little older were generally more ambivalent about their enforced conversion into self-managers. Digital tools added an additional layer of activities and responsibilities on top of the old machinery, a slew of new demands in terms of online presence and self-promotion. Two ZZK artists, Chancha Vía Circuito and Mati Zundel, ruminated about quitting the music profession in 2014, such was their distaste for the work of self- management. For all the talk about cutting out the middlemen, there was some nostalgia for them once they were gone.

In the face of such pressures, the Argentine state began to intervene and its actions suggested that changes in the nature of musical work in the digital era had the potential to alter the very conception of a musician. In 2013 the Ministry of Culture decreed that a cultural producer now also had to become a *gestor cultural* (cultural manager or promoter). One of the main aims of Recalculando, a state programme discussed below, was to teach musicians to *gestionarse* (manage themselves) and thereby convert them into *gestores*.[18] That the very word 'musician' was coming under pressure suggested that important changes were afoot, although their significance was ambiguous. In the global North, where musicians are increasingly expected to see themselves as small businesses—to acquire managerial skills and manifest self-promoting desires—such shifts are usually attributed to neoliberal 'creative economy' paradigms.[19] The *gestor cultural* discourse in Argentina might have evidenced the penetrative power of such globally circulating frameworks. Yet self-management also had a distinctive local history, one with a much more collective bent, which was being reanimated in the period of ascendance of the internet. Cooperative and self-organisation movements emerged in Argentina in the mid-1990s precisely as a critical response to neoliberal conditions and blossomed with the 2001 crisis provoked by neoliberal policies (Brand and Sekler 2009, 61–2). Self-management was thus associated locally with workers collectively occupying and taking over capitalist enterprises. Given the leftist valence of this idea in recent Argentinean history, the language of *gestores culturales* had a post-neoliberal flavour and the self-management in question was partly a matter of taking fuller advantage of increased opportunities provided by the state (described below).

[18] See, for example, http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WyQG-UwgIVQ. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[19] This was one theme that emerged from the conference 'The small economies of the "new" music industry', University of Bristol, 25 March 2013.

Other digital cumbias

Although ZZK coined the term 'digital *cumbia*' for its particular brand of fusion, other currents of laptop cumbia emerged in Buenos Aires. The genre was thus internally diverse. Around the turn of the millennium, and well before the first ZZK party, DJ Taz, DJ Yankee and the legendary *cumbia villera* musician Pablo Lescano fused cumbia, EDM and dub in a project called Su Majestad La Cumbia, and while the group did not last long, DJ Taz attempted a comeback in 2012 alongside two young former disciples, Negro Dub and Che Cumbe, who had been organising large dances under the name of Colombia Fest. Their primary audience was a subset of the 'popular-class' public at the large weekend *bailantas* (dances) that are the mainstay of the tropical music industry, and their dub versions of Colombian *cumbia* appealed mainly in the Zona Norte (the peripheral northern zone of greater Buenos Aires) where Colombian music is particularly appreciated.

In 2011 an important new subgenre emerged from the commercial *cumbia* industry, epitomised by Los Wachiturros, a group with a highly digital aesthetic that mixed elements of *cumbia*, *reggaetón*, EDM and dancehall. A raft of similar *música turra* groups soon appeared, appealing mainly to younger listeners (above all teenagers) from the popular classes in the Zona Sur (southern zone). The musical elements of *música turra* were similar to those of ZZK, but the way they were used was quite different: whereas ZZK's artists often strove to experiment with and transform these features, *música turra* producers tended towards repetition of a limited palette of generic sounds, aiming to appeal to fans of mainstream *cumbia* and *reggaetón* rather than the alternative electronica and rock scenes to which ZZK was oriented.

Música turra's sound was new, but its economic model came from its predecessor, *cumbia villera*, which had emerged in the late 1990s (Magariños and Taran 2009).[20] In *música turra*, recorded music was distributed freely by any means available in order to drum up interest and the money was made at the gate of the large weekend *bailantas*. The most successful artists might perform short sets at numerous *bailantas* in a single night. Unlike ZZK, *música turra* derived significant income (fees and royalties) from live performance, the large fanbase for commercial *cumbia* and the centrality of *bailantas* in the leisure activities of the popular classes making this model financially viable.

The director of JR Producciones, a leading *música turra* production company, had a gold disc by one of his artists, Macho y El Rey, framed and mounted on the wall of his office in classic music-industry style—but this was really about appearances rather than sales, he admitted, since they gave most of their CDs away. Forms of distribution included TV, radio, informal CDs and increasingly the internet (via specialist *cumbia* websites). But *música turra* also embodied the innovations associated with Web 2.0. By uploading their music to YouTube and social media these entrepreneurs encouraged listeners to engage not only in consumption but also in collaborative and participatory practices. JR Producciones' music producer, KR Pro aka DJ Krass, uploaded not just completed tracks but also their constituent parts and broadcast their availability via Facebook, encouraging other producers and audience members to remix the tracks, thereby making the originals more widely known—which in turn translated into greater demand at *bailantas*. Moreover he urged other DJs to publish their

[20] It also echoes the model of digital urban music scenes in Brazil (Howard-Spink 2006; Pereira de Sá and Oliveira Miranda 2012).

remixed versions on the internet or CDs: as he told me, 'It doesn't matter what version, just that when a group plays a show, people know the song and sing it.'

The remix culture of *música turra* involved fans as well as producers. YouTube was awash with homemade remixes of Los Wachiturros' hit 'Tírate un Paso', set to videos of The Simpsons or the Mexican comic character El Chavo (with millions of views), and hundreds of home videos of teenagers dancing the song's choreography.[21] The rise of *música turra* (a term whose origins lie in the music's characteristic dance moves) coincided with the global success of South Korean K-Pop and particularly Psy's 'Gangnam Style', in which fans' imitation of choreographies played a key part in their engagement. Los Wachiturros' success had much to do with the opportunities to interact with their music—to share it, remix it, dance to it and post videos of dancing to it. *Música turra* was thus highly adapted to local digital conditions and while other, more formal and middle-class sectors of the Argentinean music industry were wrestling with pay-per-download and streaming, música turra focused on fans freely sharing music online rather than paying to own or access it. *Música turra* might therefore be regarded as a forward-looking sector of the Argentinean music industry.

Laptop *cumbia* also encompassed a third subgenre with an entirely different model: netlabels, which disdained not only the sale of digital music but also the open pursuit of commercial goals. Netlabels release digital-only albums for free, sometimes under a Creative Commons licence, constituting a 'nonprofit popular music sector' built on technological and legal changes (Galuszka 2012). Such was the growth of netlabels in the digital cumbia and broader Global Bass spheres that digital cumbia blogger John Newell (2013) was moved to remark ironically: 'I think for the first time ever there are now officially more internet record labels than there are artists and DJs. … It is an online epidemic.' Their owners often viewed the selling of music askance, unless the transaction took place directly between the artist and the buyer, and some struck defiantly anti-materialistic poses. Buenos Aires-based netlabel Cabeza began its self-presentation: 'In early 2008 Lucas Luisao and Martin "negromoreno" Moreno joined forces to shape one of the least profitable projects on earth.'[22] Another digital *cumbia* blogger, Cumbiónico (2012), writing about two Latin music netlabels, proclaimed: 'Showing oneself free to distribute music for free, as the Rebel Sounds + Latino Resiste people do, is a radical form of protest against the capitalist model of cultural production.' Buenos Aires artist Catnapp released an EP on Caballito netlabel called *No Money Whatever*. On the cover she holds a fistful of fake money displaying a cat's head, again foregrounding the decommoditisation of her music. A netlabel is thus often a labour of ideology and a statement about free circulation, one that requires investment rather than generating direct revenue. This non-materialistic trend appeared to be growing: Lucas Luisao of Cabeza reported that the 'competition' between netlabels had increased markedly since 2008. (There is of course an irony in a non-profit sector being concerned with competition.) He remarked, slightly wistfully, that the number of (free) downloads of his releases was declining substantially, now that there were more netlabels in the 'business'.

Buenos Aires netlabels like Cabeza and SubKlub released a wide variety of music by many artists, making aesthetic generalisations difficult; but their output was notably oriented to-

[21] https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jVLAllwh9Tk (official video). Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=SJHpUFYFgtw (Simpsons remix). No longer available.

[22] https://soundcloud.com/cabeza-netlabel. Accessed 9 January 2022.

wards genres such as dubstep and drum'n'bass, sometimes fused with Latin American musics. Perhaps linked to their aesthetic orientation towards rapidly evolving international subgenres of EDM, netlabels were pared-down operations that offered one important advantage: speedy turnaround. There was minimal risk of a cutting-edge sound being blunted or overtaken because of a drawn-out release schedule. Tracks could be released within weeks rather than the months or years associated with, say, ZZK. Netlabels were thus closely attuned to the rapid temporality of fast-evolving contemporary digital dance music genres.

One of the main ZZK developments of 2012 was the launch of its compilation *Future Sounds of Buenos Aires*, yet the very idea of selling a compilation album arguably looked more to the past. *Música turra* and netlabels may have provided more indicative visions of the future. By abandoning the sale of recorded music and (in the case of the former) focusing instead on fans' and musicians' participatory engagement with it, *música turra* and netlabels embodied two poles—one commercial, the other anti-commercial—of current thinking about the future of music, and of music as industry, in the age of the internet. At the time, though, three different economic and aesthetic strategies coexisted within laptop cumbia as a subgenre, illustrating the fluidity of the industry, of understandings of the digital and of aesthetic practices inflected by the digital.

Cultural industries, institutions and policies

Broadening out again from digital cumbia, significant developments were occurring in the wider institutional field in 2012–13, as the state's approach to the cultural industries evolved. It was in the realm of cultural policy that the most distinctive local developments relating to music and digitisation could be observed. While fresh debates and policy initiatives were in the air, transitions into practice were limited, and most new policy directions either failed or were curtailed by the change of government in 2015. Still, given their prominent discursive presence in the cultural sector during my fieldwork, and the importance granted to them by my interlocutors, they deserve attention.

In April 2013 the Argentinean Cultural Industries Fair (MICA) took place at Tecnópolis, the government's flagship science and technology park. Tecnópolis was an educational and cultural space hosting exhibitions designed to promote a history of local technological prowess and foster a cutting-edge, scientific national imaginary, as well as serving as a venue for artistic (and particularly musical) events. Much of MICA took place in a single, open-plan, hangar-like space, which brought contrasting ideological positions into close proximity. The event was organised by the Ministry of Culture's National Office of Cultural Industries (NOCI), and the state and its leftist politics were prominently on display: one entire wall of the hangar was lined with the stands of different government ministries, while talks typically circled around themes such as social inclusion, denunciations of the market and democratisation of cultural access. Nevertheless, MICA was a trade fair and the presence of many small- and medium-sized cultural enterprises eager to do business, alongside the Ministry of Culture's pronouncements about the value of culture to the Argentine economy, also gave the event something of a New Labour-esque flavour.

In particular, MICA provided a graphic illustration of the disputed territory of culture and intellectual property in Argentina. SADAIC, CAPIF and AADI had sponsored a Café de

la Música, hosting a series of talks defending their traditionalist vision of music and IP. A few yards away, the 'hackathon', a project devoted to developing free music hardware and software, was taking place. These ideologically conflicting programmes rubbed shoulders—almost literally—for four days. Elsewhere in the building, public talks included a debate on digital culture by a distinguished panel that articulated a critical vision of the current IP regime defended by SADAIC, CAPIF and AADI. The senator Liliana Felder launched the debate by contrasting two metaphorical locations for culture—the market and the plaza—and remarked, 'I think that everyone sat here wants culture in the plaza', revealing not only her own backing for the idea of a cultural commons but also her perception that this view was widely shared across MICA. With presentations elsewhere by Taringa! Música and prominent IP critic Beatriz Busaniche, attendees were offered a full range of views under the same roof.

Rodolfo Hamawi, the director of NOCI, organised a public meeting at MICA between Taringa! and its principal adversaries (SADAIC, CAPIF, AADI and the Argentinean Book Chamber), who met to sign a letter of intent ('Taringa' 2013). This event revealed a progressive branch of the state attempting to broker a compromise between a forward-looking digitally focused enterprise and backward-looking analogue-era institutions. The outcome was inconclusive, however, with two institutions failing to send senior representatives and public pronouncements still revealing discords.

Other institutional tensions were symbolised by the very location of the fair. Tecnópolis, a national government project, was originally planned to be built in the City of Buenos Aires but, facing stiff resistance from the city's right-wing mayor, Mauricio Macri, it was eventually constructed just outside the city limits. The federal and municipal governments were in the hands of opposing political parties, ensuring a low level of coordination between their public policies. National cultural programmes stemmed from the Ministry of Culture, whereas the municipal music office, Opción Música, was based in the Ministry of Economic Development; their respective ventures thus tended to have different ideological slants, specifically with regard to the balancing of social and economic objectives, and at times even came into competition. Opción Música, which pursued a neoliberal 'creative economy' line, attempted to reinvigorate the local music industry by introducing new models from the global North, but it faced resistance from the collecting and trade societies, disinterest from the major labels and tensions with leftist federal government institutions like NOCI. Opción Música's absence from MICA was telling.

MICA thus displayed a complex picture. There were ample signs of the conservative positions, institutional tensions and resulting stasis analysed earlier in the chapter, yet also a sense that new, more progressive cultural ideologies and policies were coalescing, ones attuned to the fair's surroundings, Tecnópolis, which exemplified a post-neoliberal national technological imaginary, revolving around the state and its concern with social inclusion. In the guise of NOCI, the state positioned itself at the centre in several ways: it hosted the event; it occupied the middle ground between Taringa! and the 'analogue' institutions, between copyleft and copyright, expressing both sympathy and criticism for both sides; and, more broadly, it argued that its involvement was crucial to the healthy development of the cultural industries. The state's role in the field of digitisation and culture thus merits further analysis.

State digital initiatives

If early digital culture initiatives came primarily from the commercial sector, the state increasingly sought to drive developments in the field. From 2003 the governments of Néstor and Cristina Fernández de Kirchner defined themselves in opposition to the previous neoliberal regime and prioritised social objectives. Recognising the potential of new technologies to advance its overarching social and political goals, the government became a leading actor in the field of digitisation. Flagship schemes such as Argentina Conectada (a national fibre optic cable network), Open Digital Television, the one-laptop-per-child programme Conectar Igualdad and Tecnópolis were all framed in terms of promoting national autonomy, sovereignty and identity. They were presented as motors of social and cultural inclusion more than economic development.

The Minister of Culture, Jorge Coscia, described new technologies as possessing 'enormous educative potential' and 'at the service of the democratisation of culture' (Coscia 2012, 17). For Hamawi, 'technology is placed at the service of inclusion and diversity' and flagship digital programmes were aimed primarily at reducing social and cultural divides (*Hamawi 2012, 8)*. Such discourses were underpinned by a vision of new technologies as tending to promote concentration of wealth and opportunities if left to the market. In the hands of the state, however, they might constitute technologies of social inclusion, widening participation and national unification. Above all, the digital was understood as political. *Página 12* journalist Washington Uranga argued that 'full citizenship is not possible today without thinking about the communicational and, within it, the digital', and hence 'the digital and the communicational is a space of political struggle'.[23]

There were, therefore, close connections between the state's digital strategy, political agenda, social mission and cultural vision. Widening access to both culture and new technologies was a central goal, because they formed two pillars of national sovereignty. Infrastructural programmes were intended to allow the state to distribute more widely cultural products that might fortify national integration and identity.

Increasingly, then, the digital and the cultural went hand in hand. Argentina Conectada was designed to foster not just better communications but also the creation of 'socially valuable' cultural content. Puntos de Cultura, inspired by the Brazilian programme of the same name, funded over four hundred 'culture points', which were provided with a computer (loaded with the government-designed free operating system Huayra) and digital video cameras. Igualdad Cultural (Cultural Equality), whose tag line was 'inclusion in diversity', brought together the Ministry of Culture and the Ministry of Federal Planning, Public Investment and Services—exemplifying how culture and the digital were bound together in the national political project. Igualdad Cultural 'conceives of access to Information and Communication Technology (ICT) and culture as a fundamental right of all the inhabitants of Argentina. This initiative aims, therefore, to foster the conditions to bring about equality of opportunity across the country with regard to the creation and enjoyment of cultural goods, and access to new forms of communication.'[24] Its goal was to use new technologies to open up cultural production, distribution and consumption to every corner of Argentina, for example by

[23] http://lic.cultura.gob.ar/foros-de-cultura-digital. No longer available.

[24] http://www.igualdadcultural.gob.ar. No longer available.

broadcasting live performances via Open Digital Television and a Federal Network of Digital Culture. One planned subproject entailed the creation of an Online Music Bank, a tool for disseminating music but also facilitating the fulfilment of the quota for national music on the radio stipulated by the 2009 media law.

Another Ministry of Culture digital initiative, Plataforma Argentina de Música (PAM), was launched at MICA in 2013. PAM was an online music platform aimed at promoting the Argentinean music industry to distributors, labels and festivals around the world. It focused not on selling digital content but rather operating as a digital catalogue for the national music industry. PAM was planned as a complement to the Online Music Bank, with the former aimed at the music industry and the latter at the media and consumers. It was a commercial initiative, but like most Ministry of Culture policies, it articulated a balance between economic and social objectives and had a marked nationalist slant. Hamawi described the project as intended to promote equality and 'to put together a broader, more democratic and inclusive map of Argentinean culture'.[25] Its vision was ambitious: to offer a public-sector alternative to YouTube and iTunes, with the bonus of fostering interaction between different industry actors.

The government's policies that linked digitisation, social inclusion and cultural access and production were noteworthy, but it should be underlined that most such projects were still progressive dreams more than concrete realities at the time of my fieldwork, and few made the transition. The Online Music Bank stalled because of a clash between widening cultural access and authors' rights. There were considerable problems around the licensing of digital content produced and circulated by the state. The government's digital TV initiative included a music branch, ACUA Música, but it appeared largely inactive. The digital TV project aimed to increase the diversity of cultural offerings, but it suffered from poor coordination between different bodies and lacked a clear sense of how content creation was going to be funded over the long term (Mastrini et al. 2013). PAM appears never to have fully taken off. It cannot be argued, then, that these music and digitisation projects had significant effects. Nevertheless, they have much to tell us about digital ideologies and desires within the orbit of the state at a particular historical juncture, one that was soon to be firmly relegated to the past.

The state's increasing activity in the cultural realm bore some fruit for independent musicians, though above all in the realm of live performance. Igualdad Cultural sent artists to perform well-paid concerts around the country, again in the name of social and cultural inclusion; Miss Bolivia, a close collaborator with ZZK, was one beneficiary. In 2013 the programme had around $1 million to distribute to 200 groups to provide ten concerts each. Another Ministry of Culture programme, Recalculando, was working with around twenty musical collectives around the country, focusing on boosting live music scenes and touring opportunities (see below). Tecnópolis provided well-paid performing opportunities for a number of DJs and bands from the middle-class *cumbia* scene.

In contrast, digital initiatives appeared poorly coordinated, sometimes even in contradiction and somewhat invisible in practice. Nevertheless, they might be understood as attempts by progressive (and often younger) voices within the state to promote change in a sector dominated by more conservative (and often older) institutions and individuals. Cultural officials and experts believed that progress would be slow and laborious in the face of the

[25] http://www.mica.gob.ar/1843/la-secretaria-de-cultura-de-la-nacion-lanzo-la-plataforma-argentina-de-musica-pam/. No longer available.

indifference or contrary interests of a static local private sector and multinational enterprises with considerably larger budgets. Furthermore, they considered both the announcement of ambitious public policies and their patchy implementation to be characteristically Argentinean. It would be a mistake, then, to regard limited progress as simply a sign of insignificance.

In this regard it is worth noting that some of the most dynamic figures in the sphere of music and digitisation moved towards increasing involvement with the state at this time. Fer Isella, who made his name as a music entrepreneur, directed the music section of MICA 2013 and led the launch of PAM, while Tatu Estela gave up his job as director of Taringa! Música in mid-2014 to take up the post of Coordinator of New Technologies at the Ministry of Culture. Such moves would support an argument—one explicitly articulated by Estela—that the public sector was more appealing than the private in Argentina at the time with regard to the intersection of music and new technologies. In neoliberal contexts in the global North, it is usually the state that is cast in the role of the slow-moving or heavy-handed player while the private sector is presumed to be fleet of foot; but in Argentina, with the private sector dominated by 'analogue' institutions, progressive initiatives in this period were concentrated within the state.

'Where are the cultural industries heading?'

Placing Argentina's independent music sector in political context generates a more nuanced understanding of the stasis presented earlier. The Kirchner governments came to see the significance of digital technology as lying primarily in the social and cultural realms; public policies relating to digitisation and culture thus increasingly prioritised social inclusion and cultural participation over economic development. The music industry panorama at this time may then be seen as underpinned by post-neoliberal politics and, in particular, by critical attitudes to digital capitalism.

NOCI's list of objectives began with 'democratising access to and the production of cultural goods and services, [and] promoting geographical and economic decentralisation'.[26] Its stance may be summed up by the phrase 'digital social justice' (Loreti and Lozano 2012), found in a book that it published in 2012, *En la ruta digital*. With a prologue by NOCI's director, Rodolfo Hamawi, and the opening chapter by the culture minister, Jorge Coscia, this book represented an important strand of the government's thinking on culture and digitisation at the time. Hamawi (2012) argued for the internet as a tool of public service rather than private enterprise, while Coscia wrote of 'designing an egalitarian and redistributive digital policy' (2012, 14). The market was portrayed as exclusionary and restrictive, and authors promoted the state as guarantor of social inclusion, democratisation of culture and access to knowledge.

Natalia Calcagno, a Ministry of Culture researcher, described the genesis of NOCI's recent line, and in particular its choice of the label 'cultural industries' rather than the more contemporary 'creative industries', in terms of a deliberate rejection of the latter's neoliberal orientation (treating culture primarily as an engine of economic growth). There are notable echoes of Brazil's public policies on digital culture, summarised by Horst (2011, 451) as committed to 'digital inclusion and resistance to the broader normative order of global capitalism'. While undoubtedly influenced by such post-neoliberal policy directions in the region,

[26] http://www.cultura.gob.ar/areas/industrias-culturales/. No longer available.

NOCI's vision was characterised primarily by a rejection of specific neoliberal examples, such as the UK's approach and its exportation to countries like Colombia. The stasis described earlier in the chapter may thus be seen as underpinned not just by institutional resistance and tensions but also by the scepticism of state cultural policymakers towards free-market conceptions of progress.

Within the Ministry of Culture, progressive voices attempted to formulate a vision of post-neoliberal cultural industries. The ministry's discourse on this topic exhibited the key transformative features of Latin American post-neoliberalism, identified by Macdonald and Ruckert *(2009, 7)* as a new agenda of social inclusion and, more specifically, 'governments' willingness to use state power to stimulate the economy and correct widespread market failures; to substantially deepen democracy by engaging citizens more directly; to use state institutions to reduce social inequalities through redistributive measures; and to renationalize some parts of the economy'. *En la ruta digital* may be seen as launching a debate on the shape of Argentina's cultural industries for the post-neoliberal as well as the digital era, and indeed positing digital technology as a powerful mediator of a post-neoliberal agenda.

'Where are the cultural industries heading?' asked a debate on the book at MICA 2013. Recent achievements were held up against strong critiques of the previous neoliberal regime. Calcagno, one of the book's architects, critiqued policy responses to digital challenges in the global North as restrictive and authoritarian and articulated scepticism towards beliefs in the balancing effect of the market. Martín Becerra, a politically influential media scholar, identified two policy phases since 2003: the first saw a bolstering of the traditional media and cultural industries in the wake of the 2001 crisis; the second, beginning around 2008, saw a deeper, more politicised questioning of the whole model (see also Becerra 2013). This second phase, in which the state was more active, saw the first articulations of a post-neoliberal reconfiguration of the cultural industries, a shift that might be summarised as moves to democratise access, balance the economic and the social and redistribute profits from corporations to creators. Certainly, statements of intent were more apparent than actual reconfigurations. For example, NOCI proposed that cultural creators be rewarded from an authors' fund, financed by a tax on the profits of ISPs and telecoms, to counteract the concentration of profits in the hands of large corporations (Hamawi 2012; Calcagno and D'Alessio 2012), but no such fund was actually created. Nevertheless, more concrete examples can be seen in state initiatives such as Igualdad Cultural, the 2009 media law (with its quota for Argentinean independent music on the radio) and the 2012 National Music Law, aimed primarily at stimulating the independent music sector. [27]

En la ruta digital revealed clearly the connection between digitisation, culture and politics, and represented a statement of intent by progressive figures within the orbit of the Ministry of Culture. Recognising the futility of a direct approach to politicians, they opted instead to promote public debate around these issues within more amenable spheres, such as universities and the creative sector, with the aim of building up a critical mass of opinion that would then oblige politicians to take notice. Becerra noted that the 2009 media law—a major legislative achievement of the second Kirchner government—grew from debates among a handful of progressive individuals in the 1980s and 90s. There was thus an important precedent for this

[27] http://www.musicosconvocados.com/marco.html. Accessed 9 January 2022.

approach and evidence that it could lead to substantial change over the long term. Becerra argued that debates in forums like MICA and *En la ruta digital* served to put key issues on the public agenda. Concrete results might be thin on the ground at first, he said, and issues might even fade from view for periods of time (something that did indeed come to pass); but opening such debates was an important first step, laying the groundwork for the implementation of new ideas in the future.

Collectivism

A commonplace local reading of Buenos Aires' music industry was that it was 'behind', as evidenced by the late arrival of services such as iTunes and streaming—the implication being that it differed from that of the global North in terms of its position on a developmental curve rather than following a different trajectory. A clue to a different reading, however, was provided to me by Nicolás Falcoff, MICA panellist and director of the independent label Sura.

> We're realizing that we're not going to get anywhere on our own, that the whole is greater than the sum of its parts, that the way to work is to work collectively, that's what's coming now. I believe in work networks, in collective work, in solidarity economics, in networks of fair trade, in another way of making culture and another way of doing business … I'd tell anyone who wanted to do business to devote himself to something else, there are tons of businesses that are much more profitable than this one. The purging that took place as a result of this crisis meant that the pirates and the mercenaries really knew that there wasn't much for them here. Those of us who remain, the survivors, are organizing ourselves to see how, from an equitable starting point as far as possible, we may be able to create something a bit stronger and carry on doing what we like—which is music.

In Falcoff's vision, Buenos Aires' independent music scene, rather than presenting an inferior, belated copy of industry developments in the global North, displayed a search for alternatives to digital capitalism. His position was inspired more by social movements than capitalist entrepreneurialism, by a search for sustainability more than profit and growth. He described entrepreneurship among independent musicians in collective rather than individual terms, as 'the artist who is being empowered and saying "I want to do this, so I get together with another artist and another and we create a collective of artists to establish a work unit to put on [concert] series"; I see a lot of collective management and partnership among artists.'

State initiatives, too, were focused less on individualist entrepreneurialism than on collaboration. 'Collectives are the central actors of this new culture', stated Recalculando's promotional video.[28] This Ministry of Culture programme was working with twenty groups in mid-2013 and called them collectives, even though they were formed around record labels, because making records was only part of their activity. The term 'collective' thus signalled a shift in the nature of a record label, now conceived of as an association of artists from diverse fields engaged in a wide range of activities, with a different way of working—horizontal, collaborative, networked—and sustainability as its overriding aim. Recalculando promoted collective structures, arguing for strength in unity and a network as more than the sum of its parts. Its position was that such structures fostered a solidarity economy and eased the financial challenges that independent musicians faced under digital conditions.

[28] http://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WyQG-UwgIVQ. Accessed 9 January 2022.

Collectivism and cooperative thinking have a long history in Argentina, appearing at various points in the twentieth century. They blossomed in the late 1990s as increasing numbers of workers were marginalised under neoliberal conditions (Sitrin 2012; Zibechi 2012). The 2001 crisis saw an exponential rise of collectivism across Argentinean society, not least in the arts world (Giunta 2009, 54–64). Institutional weakness and economic hardship led artists to form collectives with a common vocabulary (horizontalism, self-management) and common traits (networked, economically autonomous, politically active and operating by consensus).

Just as this broad wave of collectivism was largely a bottom-up phenomenon, post-neoliberal reimaginings of the cultural industries were not confined to cultural officials and academics but also emerged from the independent music sphere. Falcoff presented his initiative as separate from Recalculando, as a private rather than government-sponsored programme, illustrating how collectivism circulated among independent musicians quite autonomously from government pronouncements. Indeed, many younger officials in Ministry of Culture music programmes such as Recalculando had started out in the independent music sphere. The transfer of ideas was thus just as much from the musical grassroots to politics as vice versa.

Collectivism was also a feature of the middle-class *cumbia* scene, not just in ZZK Records but also in large cumbia orchestras like La Delio Valdez, Sonora Marta la Reina, Orkesta Popular San Bomba and Cumbia Club La Maribel, which emerged from 2009. With one to two dozen players, they were not conceived as economic ventures, but rather stressed sociability over financial gain. Luciano Choque Ramos abandoned an earlier digital cumbia project, Imperio Diablo, to form Todopoderoso Popular Marcial in 2010, and he praised the symbolic impact of 'twenty people doing something together, the same thing, in real time—and it's pretty exciting what happens. You always see smaller groups or soloists or DJs or something quite individual, so seeing something more collective mobilises people'.[29] Such orchestras stood symbolically against both the digital and individualistic entrepreneurialism.

The collectivist ethos in the independent music sector thus evidenced the confluence of state and civil society ideologies and of post-neoliberal politics and subjectivities. It represented a vision of resistance among low- and mid-level actors to the intensifying corporatisation and concentration of the music industry. The currency of collectivism both within cultural institutions and among cultural producers, and its roots in local experiences after the 2001 crisis, suggested that it was more than just a passing fad or opportunistic slogan. Though it was to come under pressure as a result of future political changes, collectivism constituted a noteworthy response to digital conditions in Argentina.

Argentina in regional context

An important inspiration for Recalculando (and its predecessor, the Network of Independent Collectives or RECI) was Brazil's Fora do Eixo ('Off the Axis'), a national network of collectives that began working in 2005 to increase performing opportunities for independent musicians. The result was a national circuit, outside the structures of the mainstream music industry, to facilitate touring and reach new audiences. According to the Brazilian cultural official Jéferson Assumção (2013), Fora do Eixo (or FdE) brought a third player into the equation, alongside the state and the market: the community or collective.

[29] Interview with Luciano Choque Ramos, May 2012.

Assumção's adaptation of the state/market/civil society triad illustrates the extent to which collectivism was shaping social, cultural and political imaginaries in post-neoliberal Latin America, and the same was true in the technological sphere. Regional conceptions of the internet revolved to a considerable degree around his third term. As Garrido (2012, 94–5) noted, the internet was rarely treated as a commercial space by young people in Buenos Aires; its social and cultural aspects were paramount and ideas of networking and sharing were much more prominent than monetising. Similarly, Horst (2011) identified three key themes in the new media landscape in Brazil: digital inclusion, free culture and networked sociality. The last of these was utilised by FdE to try to strengthen independent music production across Brazil, generating publicity and audiences for live music and fostering the circulation of bands (Garland 2012, 510). The emergent collectivism in Brazilian and Argentinean independent music scenes was thus underpinned by particular local understandings of the internet.

FdE and Recalculando had fervent advocates, such as Assumção and British independent music network UnConvention.[30] It should be underlined, however, that the Brazilian network also generated a growing wave of polemics from grassroots and academic sectors (e.g., Garland 2012; Miseravel 2013). Nevertheless, such programmes were calibrated to the challenges and opportunities facing the independent music sphere in countries where the internet was conceived as functioning more effectively in fostering social networks than in selling digital content or services, and where governments placed more emphasis on digital inclusion than e-commerce.

A number of initiatives discussed in this chapter, like Recalculando, illustrate the growing links between the leftist state and the independent music sector, which had been left largely to the market during the neoliberal 1990s. The 2009 media law included a quota for Argentinean independent music on the radio, while the 2012 National Music Law gave concrete form to the sense that the independent music sector lacked economic viability and required state support, particularly in the wake of the Cromañón tragedy. NOCI's proposed authors' fund provided a further example of the state's recognition of the tendency towards the impoverishment of cultural producers in conditions of digital capitalism and its desire to intervene to alter this situation.

One might therefore identify several distinctive features of the independent music sector in Argentina and Brazil, the two largest Latin American countries to take a post-neoliberal turn in the early 2000s. One was collaboration between the state and the independent sector, based on a questioning of digital capitalism and its effects on smaller players. Both sides agreed that state intervention provided a necessary rebalancing of a rapidly concentrating field. Digitisation was seen as both a threat and an opportunity, with the market posing the former and the state guaranteeing the latter, and—in this vision—the opportunity was social and cultural more than economic. A second feature was collectivism. If the spread of digital technology fostered a 'do it yourself' independent ethos in the 1990s, the 2000s saw the rise of 'do it together'—also making extensive use of new technologies, but underpinned by a more collaborative ideology. A third was the particular characteristics of internet use, which focused on digital inclusion and networked sociality and thus supported the collectivist paradigm.

[30] https://www.unconventionhub.org/. Accessed 9 January 2022.

Viewing Argentina through the lens of Assumção's triad of state, collective and market, three conceptions of digital technology appeared to be at stake. For the state, digital technology was primarily a technology of social justice and cultural participation; for the collectivist paradigm, a technology of social aggregation and networking; and for the market, a technology of economic development and profit. These three conceptions were not mutually exclusive and many initiatives, both state and private, incorporated all three to different degrees; the issue was therefore one of emphasis. That said, *En la ruta digital* articulated a direct contest between the state and market visions of new technologies and it advanced a post-neoliberal line on the social potential of digitisation and its intimate connection to culture. In relation to the independent music sector, with commercial digital initiatives struggling, it was arguably in the first two realms that the most noteworthy developments were taking place in 2011–13, and the first two ideologies of the digital were in the ascendant. The state's digital initiatives and the collectivist movements, and their mutual interactions, showcased at events like MICA 2013, aspired to shape a post-neoliberal music industry, and their efforts, however abortive they turned out to be, constituted a distinctive contribution to global music industry debates.

Coda

The election of the centre-right candidate Mauricio Macri as president in late 2015, after twelve years of leftist governments, changed Argentina's political complexion overnight. It also provoked a wave of profound concern within the independent cultural sector. As mayor of Buenos Aires, Macri had been known to independent musicians mainly as the force behind the closure of many small venues and the imposer of restrictive legislation.

Two important shifts can be noted in the Macri period. One was the waging of a 'culture war' on the Kirchners' legacy.[31] This campaign focused not just on projects explicitly tied to the former presidents, such as the Kirchner Cultural Centre, but also on social and cultural programmes such as the school netbook initiative Conectar Igualdad.[32] The other shift was a return to neoliberal ideologies and more market-based policies, with effects immediately felt in the cultural field. For example, the progressive National Office of Cultural Industries (NOCI) was closed, to be replaced by a Department of Culture and Creativity, led by Enrique Avogadro, a former cultural official in Macri's right-wing city government. The department immediately abandoned NOCI's 'cultural industries' focus in favour of a 'creative economy' line, initiating a Network of Creative Cities.[33] Whereas the collective had emerged in the Kirchner years as an important cultural player, 2016 saw the installation of the entrepreneur at the heart of the government's imaginary.[34] The collectivist music programme Recalculando was disbanded, its *gestores culturales* replaced by Argentina Creativa's *emprendedores culturales* (cultural entrepreneurs). The Online Music Bank, which had changed focus and moved towards digitising old tango and folklore records, was also shut down. The day after the election, its

[31] http://lab.org.uk/argentina-culture-wars. Accessed 9 January 2022.

[32] http://aerom.com.ar/el-vergonzoso-titulo-de-clarin-para-justificar-el-fin-de-conectar-igualdad/. No longer available.

[33] http://redciudadescreativas.cultura.gob.ar. No longer available.

[34] https://www.rebelion.org/noticias/2016/4/210927.pdf. No longer available.

director, Tatu Estela, was refused access to his office in the Kirchner Cultural Centre; most of his team were fired and other cultural programmes were removed from the building.[35]

It should be recalled, however, that even a year before the election, many of the enterprises and initiatives considered in this chapter were struggling either to get off the ground or to continue operating. The 'active state' had formulated ambitious, progressive plans for digitisation and culture, focusing on connectivity, visibility and redistribution of revenue, yet it was having little impact on musicians or the circulation of music. Its digital music initiatives made no dent in the dominance of Facebook and YouTube, far and away the most visited websites in Argentina ('Encuesta nacional' 2013). Taringa! Música and PAM, local initiatives from the private and public sector respectively, had failed to challenge the hegemony of behemoths from the global North. Taringa! Música was going to be the Latin American Spotify, until Spotify got there first. PAM, meanwhile, appeared defunct. Not all the stunted growth or demise of such developments can therefore be laid at the door of Macri's government.

If we consider such programmes in terms of their effects, they appear insignificant. If we consider them, however, in terms of the thinking behind them, they tell us much about efforts from both public and private sectors to construct alternatives to dominant models of digital capitalism. They may have disappeared under pressure from global forces, multinational corporations and changing national political priorities, yet their fragility and evanescence makes it all the more important to document and analyse them.

From the perspective of independent musicians to whom I spoke in 2016, the panorama appeared unpromising, even worrying. If leftist governments had been able to do little to stem the concentration of rewards in the hands of an established elite of major concert promoters and performers, many of them foreign, a right-wing government that actively supported this process looked unlikely to emerge as a saviour. Even without the political change—a depressing development for many alternative-minded musicians—conditions were hardly favourable for large swathes of the Argentine music industry.

In a frank magazine interview over a year before the election, Grant Dull declared that 'the industry is shit … full of bad vibes and sharks' (Erbar 2014). He acknowledged publicly that the label usually lost money or at best broke even; that every year he considered giving up; and, more poignantly, that 'money and the suffering of wanting to make a business among friends is always going to damage friendship'. By 2014 most of ZZK's artists retained only a tenuous link to the label. Some had signed with other labels or released albums independently, leaving ZZK with leftovers: a digital release, a percentage of a back catalogue, or a booking or management fee. There had been a proliferation of micro-deals as each artist negotiated each aspect of their activity separately. As one told me, they had come to the realisation that the label was not going to make a living for any of them, so each one was now trying to make their own way without completely abandoning the ZZK brand.

This downbeat picture found echoes in reports from elsewhere in Latin America, such as Mexico City (Woodside Woods et al. 2012), where the flourishing of creative innovation was accompanied by 'the extensive exclusion of the majority and the condemnation of creatives to intermittency and precarity' (García Canclini and Urteaga 2012, 203). In Santiago de Chile, the majors retrenched; independent labels were scarce and run on a shoestring; there were

[35] Such shifts in the institutional landscape are illustrated by the disappearance of a number of the webpages that I used in drafting this chapter.

few small to medium venues; independent artists suffered from lack of audiences; and profit was almost entirely concentrated in mega-concerts by international artists (Solís 2010). One frustrated musician labelled Santiago's independent scene as 'in intensive care' (Solís 196)—worse than 'in the waiting room'.

Nevertheless, there were also some grounds for more optimistic assessments. The Digital Music Reports for 2012 to 2014 reported strong growth across the region and predicted a bright future for the digital music business in Latin America. The 2017 IFPI Global Music Report announced that Latin America was the region with the highest level of growth in revenue from recorded music for the seventh consecutive year, with a 12 per cent rise. Digital revenue grew by 31.2 per cent and streaming revenue by 57 per cent.[36] The previous year, Argentina had seen an increase of 34.8 per cent in revenue from recorded music, thanks to a 140 per cent rise in digital revenues, and streaming was making increasing inroads, representing 86.6 per cent of the digital market.[37]

Within the scene that I studied, ZZK Records' fortunes were waxing again by 2017, on the back of several productive crowdfunding campaigns and the international success of Nicola Cruz, who signed to the label in 2015. Grant Dull launched a new venture in Ecuador *(AYA Records)* and focused increasingly on making documentaries outside of Argentina *(ZZK Films)*. Back in Buenos Aires, success stories could be found among post-digital projects such as traditionalist middle-class *cumbia* orchestras (such as La Delio Valdez) and neo-World Music bands (such as La Yegros), rather than more experimental digital projects. A more upbeat picture could also be seen in *música turra*, which showed similarities with Brazilian digital music scenes like tecnobrega, baile funk and electronic forró. These scenes, with their enthusiastic adoption of new technologies, legitimisation of informal copying and distribution, and emphasis on live performance, have been held up as innovative responses to the crisis in the recording industry and possible models for the future (see 'The Paraense Tecnobrega' n.d.; Howard-Spink 2006; Comin 2011; Krauskopf n.d.; Pereira de Sá and Oliveira Miranda 2012). Vianna (2011, 247) argued that such vibrant and inventive new music economies, which were emerging on the edges of large Brazilian cities, might point the way forward for the mainstream music industry.

Still, there was continued uncertainty over which of these futures lay ahead, suggesting the continued aptness of the metaphor of the waiting room—although it might also be argued that the independent sector's struggles had been going on for so long in Buenos Aires that they were actually the destination. However, this metaphor serves, above all, to capture the sense of uncertainty within the sector at a particular historical juncture. In 2012 the independent music industry sensed change coming, but was pulled in several directions at once. The city government's Opción Música regarded the local music industry as needing to be brought up to date with developments in the global North; it thus focused on translating new business models from the outside world to Argentina. The Ministry of Culture and NOCI looked to other sources of inspiration, such as the egalitarian, redistributive cultural policies of Brazil. To generalise, the city government sought to stimulate digital entrepreneurialism while the national government spoke of digital social justice. In both cases, Argentina was seen as behind, and policies were designed to pull it forwards, though in different directions,

[36] http://www.ifpi.org/downloads/GMR2017.pdf. No longer available.

[37] http://www.revistapym.com.co/destacados/mercado-musica-streaming-2016. No longer available.

illustrating divergent orientations to two rival spheres of influence on Argentina—the global North and Latin America—and to the neoliberal and post-neoliberal ideologies that coexisted and competed in Buenos Aires' cultural sector. Complicating the picture further were the old 'analogue' institutions—particularly the collecting and trade societies—which, with their eye on the past, tended to resist both of the competing new models. It was unsurprising, then, that the independent music sector felt like it was stuck in the waiting room.

References

'Argentina. International Intellectual Property Alliance (IIPA) 2012 Special 301 Report on Copyright Protection and Enforcement.' 2012. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.semanticscholar.org/paper/Priority-Recommended-Actions-for-Argentina-in-2012-/9dbf1a58ee995b0ac274149193125635252e17c5

Assumção, Jéferson. 2013. 'A América Latina saindo dos eixos.' *Outras Palavras*, 20 April. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://outraspalavras.net/2013/04/20/a-america-latina-saindo-dos-eixos/

Baker, Geoffrey. 2015a. 'Digital *Cumbia*, Circulation of Music, and Music of Circulation: "El Alto de La Paz,"' in *Pieces of the Musical World: Approaches to the Study of Music in Culture*, edited by Rachel Harris and Rowan Pease, 249–64. London: Routledge.

Baker, Geoffrey. 2015b. '"Digital Indigestion": *Cumbia*, Class and a Post-digital Ethos in Buenos Aires.' *Popular Music* 34, no. 2: 175–96.

Barrowclough, Diana and Zeljka Kozul-Wright. 2011. 'Voice, Choice and Diversity Through Creative Industries: Towards A New Development Agenda.' In *Creative Industries and Developing Countries: Voice, Choice and Economic Growth*, edited by Diana Barrowclough and Zeljka Kozul-Wright, 3–36. Abingdon: Routledge.

Baym, Nancy K. 2010. 'Rethinking the Music Industry.' *Popular Communication: The International Journal of Media and Culture* 8, no. 3: 177–80.

Becerra, Martín. 2013. 'Análisis crítico de las políticas de comunicación en el ciclo kirchnerista 2003–2013.' 5 May. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://martinbecerra.wordpress.com/2013/05/05/analisis-critico-de-las-politicas-de-comunicacion-en-el-ciclo-kirchnerista-2003-2013/

Becerra, Martín, Santiago Marino and Guillermo Mastrini. 2012. 'Mapping Digital Media: Argentina.' London: Open Society Foundations.

Brand, Ulrich, and Nicola Sekler. 2009. 'Struggling Between Autonomy and Institutional Transformations: Social Movements in Latin America and the Move Towards Post-Neoliberalism.' In *Post-Neoliberalism in the Americas*, edited by Laura Macdonald and Arne Ruckert, 54–70. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

Calcagno, Natalia and Francisco D'Alessio. 2012. '¿Analogías de lo analógico? Reflexiones sobre economía cultural en el mundo digital.' In *En la ruta digital: cultura, convergencia tecnológica y acceso*, 20–31. Buenos Aires: Secretaría de Cultura de la Presidencia de la Nación.

Comin, Mike. 2011. 'Will Brazil's Fresh Look at Copyright Become the Future of the Music Industry?' *International IP Policy*, 5 November. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://siulaw.typepad.com/international_ip_policy/2011/11/will-brazils-fresh-look-at-copyright-become-the-future-of-the-music-industry-mike-comin.html

'Confirman juicio oral para los dueños de Taringa por las descargas ilegales.' 2012. Infobae, 10 September. No longer available. http://www.infobae.com/notas/669673-Confirman-juicio-oral-para-duenos-de-Taringa-por-descargas-ilegales.html

Coscia, Jorge. 2012. 'Estado y cultura en la Argentina digital.' In *En la ruta digital: cultura, convergencia tecnológica y acceso*, 13–19. Buenos Aires: Secretaría de Cultura de la Presidencia de la Nación.

Cottrell, Stephen. 2010. 'Ethnomusicology and the Music Industries: An Overview.' *Ethnomusicology Forum* 19, no. 1: 3–25.

Cumbiónico. 2012. 'Don't Buy Music (Make It)!—A Lesson from Rebel Sounds + Latino Resiste.' *Nu Cumbia Experience*, 28 May. No longer available. http://nucumbiaexperience.com/2012/05/28/buy-music-make-it-lesson-rebel-soundslatino-resiste/

Cunningham, Stuart, Mark David Ryan, Michael Keane and Diego Ordonez. 2011. 'Financing Creative Industries in Developing Countries.' In *Creative Industries and Developing Countries: Voice, Choice and Economic Growth*, edited by Diana Barrowclough and Zeljka Kozul-Wright, 65–110. Abingdon: Routledge.

'Digital Music Report: Music at the Touch of a Button.' 2011. IFPI.

'El background detrás de los mega conciertos.' 2012. *Mirabaires*, 20 July. No longer available. http://mirabaires.com/pefiles/empresas/item/1957-el-background-detrás-de-los-mega-conciertos

Elavsky, Charles M. 2013. 'Czech Republic.' In *The International Recording Industries*, edited by Lee Marshall, 95–113. Abingdon: Routledge.

En la ruta digital: cultura, convergencia tecnológica y acceso. 2012. Buenos Aires: Secretaría de Cultura de la Presidencia de la Nación.

'Encuesta nacional de consumos culturales.' 2013. Buenos Aires: Ministerio de Cultura. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.sinca.gob.ar/VerDocumento.aspx?IdCategoria=10.

Erbar, Melanie. 2014. 'Porque todo género musical necesita sus pioneros.' *Revista Mock*, 26 June. No longer available. http://revistamock.com/porque-todo-genero-musical-necesita-sus-pioneros/

Fernández L'Hoeste, Héctor and Pablo Vila, eds. 2013. *Cumbia! Scenes of a Migrant Latin American Music Genre*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Frith, Simon, Martin Cloonan and John Williamson. 2009. 'On Music as a Creative Industry.' In *Creativity, Innovation and the Cultural Economy*, edited by Andy Pratt and Paul Jeffcutt, 74–89. Abingdon: Routledge.

Galuszka, Patryk. 2012. 'The Rise of the Nonprofit Popular Music Sector—The Case of Netlabels.' In *Music, Business and Law: Essays on Contemporary Trends in the Music Industry*, edited by Antti-Ville Kärjä, Lee Marshall and Johannes Brusila, 65–90. Helsinki: IASPM Norden & Turku International Institute for Popular Culture.

García Canclini, Néstor and Maritza Urteaga. 2012. 'Epílogo. Estrategias creativas: Entre precariedad y redes.' In *Cultura y desarrollo: Una vision crítica desde los jóvenes*, edited by Néstor García Canclini and Maritza Urteaga, 189–206. Buenos Aires: Paidós.

Garland, Shannon. 2012. '"The Space, the Gear, and Two Big Cans of Beer": Fora do Eixo and the Debate over Circulation, Remuneration, and Aesthetics in the Brazilian Alternative Market.' *Journal of Popular Music Studies* 24, no. 4: 509–31.

Garrido, Natalia. 2012. 'Identidades y "cibercultura": una aproximación a los consumos culturales en los sitios de redes sociales en internet.' In *Mi Buenos Aires querido: Entre la democratización cultural y la desigualdad educative*, edited by Ana Wortman, 85–103. Buenos Aires: Prometeo.

Giunta, Andrea. 2009. *Poscrisis: arte argentino después de 2001*. Buenos Aires: Siglo Veintiuno Editores.

Hamawi, Rodolfo. 2012. 'Prólogo.' In *En la ruta digital: cultura, convergencia tecnológica y acceso*, 7–9. Buenos Aires: Secretaría de Cultura de la Presidencia de la Nación.

Hesmondhalgh, David. 2012. *The Cultural Industries*, 3rd ed. London: Sage.

Horst, Heather A. 2011. 'Free, Social, and Inclusive: Appropriation and Resistance of New Media Technologies in Brazil.' *International Journal of Communication* 5: 437–62.

Howard-Spink, Sam. 2006. 'Brazil's Two Music Industries.' *Open Democracy,* 5 September. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.opendemocracy.net/en/brazil_music_3880jsp/

Irisarri, Victoria. 2011. ' "Por Amor al Baile": Música, tecnologías digitales y modos de profesionalización en un grupo de DJs-productores de Buenos Aires.' Masters diss., Instituto de Altos Estudios Sociales, Universidad Nacional de San Martín, Argentina.

Johnston, Maura. 2012. 'Six Reasons Why "If You Want to Get Paid For Music You Should Play It Live" Is An Idiotic Argument.' 15 November. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://maura.tumblr.com/post/35768813801/six-reasons-why-if-you-want-to-get-paid-for-music-you

Kantor, Damián. 2013. 'River, segundo en el ranking de estadios para dar recitals.' *Clarín,* 21 April. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.clarin.com/economia/titulo_0_rJrZXgYjwXx.html

Krauskopf, Ana Domb. n.d. 'Tacky and Proud: Exploring Tecnobrega's Value Network.' Cambridge, MA: MIT.

'La industria de la música en la ciudad de Buenos Aires: Cambios y perspectivas del sector en la era digital.' 2011. Buenos Aires: Dirección de Industrias Creativas.

'La industria del disco: Economía de las PyMEs de la industria discográfica en la Ciudad de Buenos Aires.' 2004. Buenos Aires: Observatorio de Industrias Culturales.

Laing, Dave. 2009. 'World Music and the Global Music Industry: Flows, Corporations and Networks.' In *World Music: Roots and Routes*, edited by Tuulikki Pietilä, 14–33. Studies across Disciplines in the Humanities and Social Sciences 6. Helsinki: Helsinki Collegium for Advanced Studies.

Lamacchia, María Claudia. 2012. *Otro cantar: La música independiente en Argentina*. Buenos Aires: Unísono.

Lee, Benjamin, and Edward LiPuma. 2002. 'Cultures of Circulation: The Imaginations of Modernity.' *Public Culture* 14: 191–213.

Leurdijk, Andra and Ottilie Nieuwenhuis. 2012. 'Statistical, Ecosystems and Competitiveness Analysis of the Media and Content Industries: The Music Industry.' Seville: Joint Research Centre of the European Commission.

Loreti, Damián and Luis Lozano. 2012. 'Nociones sobre justicia social digital en el entorno de la convergencia.' In *En la ruta digital: cultura, convergencia tecnológica y acceso*, 45–56. Buenos Aires: Secretaría de Cultura de la Presidencia de la Nación.

Macdonald, Laura and Arne Ruckert. 2009. 'Post-Neoliberalism in the Americas: An Introduction.' In *Post-Neoliberalism in the Americas*, edited by Laura Macdonald and Arne Ruckert, 1–18. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.

Madrid, Alejandro L. 2008. *Nor-tec Rifa! Electronic Dance Music from Tijuana to the World*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Magariños, Paula and Carlos Taran. 2009. 'Argentina *Cumbia Villera* Research Final Report.' Rio de Janeiro: Fundação Getulio Vargas.

Marshall, Wayne. 2010. '*Cumbia* Worlds from Ol' to Nu to You.' *Wayne & Wax*, 14 October. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://wayneandwax.com/?p=4247

Mastrini, Guillermo, Martín Becerra, Ana Bizberge, and Fernando Krakowiak. 2013. 'Policies for the Development of Digital Terrestrial Television in Argentina.' *International Journal of Digital Television* 4, no. 3: 299–311.

Miseravel, Baderneiro. 2013. 'Understanding the Circuit of Fora do Eixo.' 28 February. Accessed 30 January 2022. http://libcom.org/library/understanding-circuit-fora-do-eixo

Netto, Michel Nicolau. 2012. 'Monetising The Music: The New Characteristics of The Recorded Music Field.' In *Music, Business and Law: Essays on contemporary trends in the music industry*, edited by Antti-Ville Kärjä, Lee Marshall and Johannes Brusila, 47–64. Helsinki: IASPM Norden & Turku International Institute for Popular Culture.

Newell, John (El Guero Unico). 2013. 'Netlabel Epidemicalyopsis (Digital Record Label Epidemic).' *Generation Bass*, 12 January. No longer available. http://generationbass.com/2013/01/12/sexxy-saturday-cumbia-netlabel-epidemicalyopsis-digital-record-label-epidemic/

Ochoa, Ana María and Carolina Botero. 2009. 'Notes on Practices of Musical Exchange in Colombia.' *Popular Communication* 7, no. 3: 158–68.

Ochoa, Ana María and George Yúdice. 2002. 'The Latin American Music Industry in an Era of Crisis.' Paris: The Global Alliance for Cultural Diversity, UNESCO. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://citeseerx.ist.psu.edu/viewdoc/download?doi=10.1.1.195.6607&rep=rep1&type=pdf

'Otro querellante se baja de la causa contra Taringa!' 2014. *Infobae*, 20 March. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://www.infobae.com/2014/03/20/1551641-otro-querellante-se-baja-la-causa-contra-taringa

Pagola, Lila. 2010. 'Efecto copyleft avant la lettre: o cómo explicar el copyleft donde todos lo practicamos.' In *Argentina copyleft: la crisis del modelo de derecho de autor y las prácticas para democratizar la cultura*, edited by Beatriz Busaniche, 35–42. Villa Allende: Fundación Vía Libre.

'The Paraense *Tecnobrega Open Business* Model.' n.d. Rio de Janeiro: Fundação Getulio Vargas.

Pereira de Sá, Simone and Gabriela de Oliveira Miranda. 2012. 'Economic Aspects of Brazilian Popular Music: The Baile Funk Circuit.' *IASPM Journal* 3, no. 1: 9–18.

Rogers, Jim. 2013. *The Death and Life of the Music Industry in the Digital Age*. London: Bloomsbury.

Sánchez, Sergio. 2014. 'Hoy se está revalorizando el baile.' *Página* 12, 7 June. Accessed 30 January 2022. http://www.pagina12.com.ar/diario/suplementos/espectaculos/3-32454-2014-06-07.html

Semán, Pablo and Pablo Vila, eds. 2011. *Cumbia: nación, etnia y género en Latinoamérica*. Buenos Aires: Editorial Gorla.

Sitrin, Marina. 2012. *Everyday Revolutions: Horizontalism and Autonomy in Argentina*. London: Zed Books.

Solís, Valeria. 2010. 'Suena desafinado: Tomando el pulso a la industria de la música en Chile.' Accessed 30 January 2022. http://goo.gl/ltorZ6

Strachan, Robert. 2007. 'Micro-Independent Record Labels in the UK: Discourse, DIY Cultural Production and the Music Industry.' *European Journal of Cultural Studies* 10, no. 2: 245–65.

'Taringa y las entidades de protección intelectual firmaron un acuerdo de trabajo conjunto.' 2013. Telam, 12 April. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://www.telam.com.ar/notas/201304/13860-taringa-y-las-entidades-de-proteccion-intelectual-firmaron-un-acuerdo-de-trabajo-conjunto.html

Totah, José. 2014. '¿El crimen no paga y el músico sí?' Página 12, 26 June. Accessed 30 January 2022. http://www.pagina12.com.ar/diario/suplementos/no/subnotas/7073-852-2014-06-26.html

'Valor y símbolo: Dos siglos de industrias culturales en la Argentina.' 2010. Buenos Aires: Secretaría de Cultura de la Presidencia de la Nación.

Vianna, Hermano. 2011. 'Technobrega, Forró, Lambadão: The Parallel Music of Brazil.' In *Brazilian Popular Music and Citizenship*, edited by Idelber Avelar and Christopher Dunn, 240–49. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Vila, Pablo and Pablo Semán. 2011. *Troubling Gender: Youth and Cumbia in Argentina's Music Scene*. Philadelphia: Temple University Press.

Woodside Woods, Julián, Claudia Jiménez López and Martiza Urteaga. 2012. 'Creatividad y desarrollo: La música popular alternativa.' In *Cultura y desarrollo: Una vision crítica desde los jóvenes*, edited by Néstor García Canclini and Maritza Urteaga, 135–88. Buenos Aires: Paidós.

Zibechi, Raúl. 2012 *Territories in Resistance: A Cartography of Latin American Social Movements*, trans. R. Ryan. Oakland, CA: AK Press.

Discography

Frikstailers 2013, track for K-Mart advertisement. Accessed 9 January 2022. http://www.ispot.tv/ad/7Ihu/kmart-layaway-dream-pool-song-by-frikstailers.

Gotan Project 2011, *La Revancha en Cumbia*, Ya Basta! Records. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=awR63tm-O5A&list=PL728126CAF0D66B92.

Mati Zundel 2012, track for Aerolineas Argentinas advertisement. No longer available. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3PTfi50YgW4

Mati Zundel 2012, 'Por el pueblo,' *Amazónico Gravitante*, ZZK Records/Waxploitation. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=pHkzRyQi2dM.

Mati Zundel 2012, 'El Alto de La Paz,' *Amazónico Gravitante*, ZZK Records/Waxploitation. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Yjow4fibUuA.

Miriam Garcia & Alicia Solans 2010, 'Pintar el Sol' (Chancha Vía Circuito remix), *Rio Arriba*, ZZK Records. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=9CAzSMAqS10.

Miriam García & Chancha Vía Circuito 2013, 'Pintar el sol,' July 13, Centro Nacional de la Música, Buenos Aires. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XPO-MT6zkiI.

El Remolón / Constitución: 'Amplificado' (Argentina) 2013. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=eY7SVqfS7q0.

Tremor 2014, 'Huella,' September 20 & October 3, 2013 @ C. C. Konex, Buenos Aires. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K9Bo43KU3EI&t=155s.

Los Wachiturros 2011, 'Tírate un paso,' Hamster Records. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jVLAllwh9Tk.

La Yegros 2013, 'El bendito,' *Viene de Mi*, ZZK Records/Waxploitation. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5AnuawYM9mg.

La Yegros 2013, 'Viene de mi,' *Viene de Mi*, ZZK Records/Waxploitation. Accessed 9 January 2022. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WtsjrvwqIr0.